

The Deconstruction of Faith

*Why People Are Leaving the Church — and What Comes
After*

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The Deconstruction of Faith

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Published by LiveWell by James Bell. Unless otherwise noted,
Scripture quotations are from the English Standard Version (ESV).

ISBN: _____

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INTRODUCTION

The Exodus Nobody Wanted

*Why Americans Are Leaving the Church, What the
Rise of the Nones Actually Means, and Who This
Book Is For — Deconstructors, Pastors, and Parents*

Consider the woman who gave fifteen years to youth ministry — who led worship and taught Bible studies, who went on three mission trips to places where the electricity cut out every afternoon, who led other people's children to Jesus and prayed with her own children every night from the moment they could form words. At thirty-eight she wrote her pastor a letter explaining why she was done, and her pastor, a good man, read it carefully and still could not find in it the thing he had missed.

What he had missed was not in the letter. The letter named the abuse scandals, and the way the church voted on the election the year her grandmother died, and the third miscarriage and the women who told her God must have a plan; two pages long, every paragraph a true thing, and not one of them the thing. Because the thing was that

She is not rare, and that is the whole problem. The people leaving the American church are not, for the most part, people who never loved Jesus; they are people who loved him enough to notice when he was quietly replaced with something easier to market. None of which is a defense of American Christianity, which in its most common expressions does not deserve one — nor is it a celebration of leaving, because most of what people find when they walk out is colder, thinner, and lonelier than they were promised it would be. The honest account is harder than either consolation: the thing they walked away from and the thing they went looking for are both, in many cases, distortions of the same original. There is a third thing, older than the brand they left and stranger than the freedom they were sold, and the pages that follow are an invitation to go find it.

FOUR READERS, ONE ROOM: THE DECONSTRUCTOR, THE PASTOR, THE PARENT, AND THE FAITHFUL

This book is written toward four people at once, and the first is the deconstructor who has not landed anywhere — the one who read the books and listened to the podcasts, who cried in the car after the service one Sunday and simply did not go back. You are not a villain in a church newsletter; you are a person who noticed something, and what you noticed deserves to be taken seriously, which

The second is the pastor watching his people leave with nothing in his hands to say. You have tried the apologetics and the more Jesus-centered preaching, the small groups, the mental health resources, the vulnerable sermons about your own doubts; some of it helped, and some of it felt like shouting down a well and waiting for the splash. What is actually happening in the room when a woman who grew up in your church tells you she cannot do it anymore is almost never what you think it is, and the gap between what you think and what is true is most of why you keep losing her.

The third is the parent whose adult child has stopped coming home for Easter — who blames in turn the college, the boyfriend or the girlfriend, the internet, and last of all and most of all themselves, who prays every single day and goes silent when the phone finally rings because there is nothing safe left to say. This book wants to give you something to say. More than that, and harder than that, it wants to give you something to stop saying.

The fourth is the faithful church member who has not deconstructed and honestly cannot imagine why anyone would — who loves the church and the pastor, who reads the Bible, sees plainly what it says, and trusts it. Nothing here is written to shake you; it is written so that when your neighbor or your niece or your coworker begins to wobble, you will recognize what is actually happening underneath the wobble, and you will not make it worse by leaping to defend a version of Christianity the Bible never taught in

THE SCALE OF THE THING: WHAT THE RISE OF THE NONES AND THE DECLINE OF CHRISTIANITY REVEAL

What is being described here is not anecdotal, and the numbers leave no room to pretend it is. Pew Research has tracked the decline for two decades: the share of Americans who identify as Christian has fallen from roughly eighty percent at the turn of the century to somewhere near sixty-five percent today, and the curve is accelerating rather than leveling off — and among adults under thirty the figures are worse still. The fastest-growing religious category in the United States is now none. Not atheist. Not agnostic. None.

The person who checks that box is not, in most cases, making a philosophical claim about the nonexistence of God; she is making a far more practical claim about the irrelevance of the institutional church to the actual shape of her life. That distinction is the one the church has spent twenty years missing, because it has treated the exodus as an intellectual problem to be solved with sharper arguments, when the arguments were never the problem. The institution is the problem. For millions of Americans it has become synonymous with hypocrisy, abuse, political manipulation, and intellectual dishonesty — and whether that perception is fair in every individual case is beside the point, because the perception is the reality the church now lives inside, and the church, by its own conduct, created most of it.

Precision is owed on one more point before any of this goes further. The word deconstruction, as the popular conversation throws it around, means radically different things to different people: for some it is the total rejection of the Christian faith, for some the rejection of one tradition within that faith while holding open the possibility of landing in another, for some a season of questioning that may or may not end in departure, for some the slow erosion of convictions that were never deeply held to begin with, and for some the traumatic break from a church that abused them. These are not the same process, and they do not call for the same response — yet one of the defining failures of the current conversation is its insistence on treating them as a single phenomenon with a single cause. They are not. This book distinguishes between them and answers each one on its own terms.

WHAT THIS BOOK IS NOT: BEYOND APOLOGETICS AND A SOFTENED FAITH

It is not a list of answers to objections. The apologetics industry has produced enough of those to fill a library, and most deconstructors have already read the better half of it;

Neither is it a soft Christianity with the edges sanded off until nothing can cut. The faith is not flexible in its essentials — Jesus rose from the dead or he did not, he is Lord or he is not, Scripture is true or it is not, and there is no third option on any of those claims, so pretending there is amounts to a failure of love dressed up as kindness. What is flexible, and what gets confused for the faith itself, is the cultural packaging Americans have wrapped around the essentials so tightly and for so long that in the average pew the packaging and the thing it covers have become indistinguishable. The packaging is not the faith. Telling the difference between the two is most of this book's work.

No writer who pretends to have no skin in this should be trusted, and the writer of these pages does not pretend to. He came to faith out of atheism, in a small group of college students who answered his questions rather than deflecting them; he has been a pastor for more than a decade in a small Michigan town; he has doubted, and he has watched people he loved walk away, and he has said things from the pulpit he would not say now and held positions so confidently that he later had to unlearn them in public. None of this is written from above anyone. It is written from inside the room — the room where people fall apart and the room where they slowly find their footing again — by someone who has stood in both long enough to know what the walls look like.

If you are in one of those rooms, the offer is simple: to sit across from you for the length of this book and say some true things as clearly as they can be said. You do not

A word on order. The book is written in a sequence, but the reader is under no obligation to follow it: a parent whose child has left should start with the chapter on parents; a pastor trying to figure out what on earth to preach this Sunday should start with doubt, or with hell; a deconstructor who wants to know whether reconstruction is even possible should start there; and anyone simply angry at the church, wondering whether this book sees what they see, should start with spiritual abuse. The book is built to be entered from many doors at once. Each chapter assumes you have not read the others, so that while the argument does build across the whole, every piece can stand on its own — and it is far better to read the one chapter you actually need than to read in sequence and give up three chapters before you reach it.

There is no chapter here that did not need to be written, and none of them was written without cost, because the subject simply does not permit distance. The aim throughout has been to close the distance — between the page and the reader, between the pastor and the person who no longer trusts him, between the institution and the human being it failed. Whether the aim has been met is for the reader, and no one else, to decide. The minimum the subject demanded was the attempt. Turn the page.

CHAPTER ONE

What Deconstruction Actually Is

*A Working Definition of Faith Deconstruction —
Deconstruction, Deconversion, and Renovation,
and Why the Difference Decides Where People Land*

The word has been ruined, and that is where we have to begin. Fifteen years ago deconstruction belonged to literary theory and the occasional theology seminar, and almost nobody outside a graduate room used it at all; five years ago it surfaced in Instagram bios and podcast titles; today it functions less as a description than as a flag, and to the right of that flag stand the people who want you to know they are done with the American church, while to the left stand the people who want you to know they are not. The flag has come loose from the thing it was meant to describe.

If we are going to get anywhere useful, we need the word back, and we need it in a specific sense. Deconstruction is the process of examining the beliefs you inherited to determine which are actually load-bearing,



Now the Bereans were of more noble character than the Thessalonians, for they received the message with great eagerness and examined the Scriptures every day to see if what Paul said was true.

— ACTS 17:11

Paul commended them for it, and Luke put the story in the Bible, which is to say the practice carries an apostolic endorsement that the people warning against it tend to forget. A church that does not continuously examine its own teaching against Scripture is not being faithful; it is being lazy. That is the honest version of the word.

What most people mean when they say deconstruction today is narrower and more combustible: they mean a specific crisis of trust that a specific generation of American Christians is having with a specific version of American Christianity. The crisis is real, even if the word was dragged into the culture war and beaten half to death on the way there. We can still use it — we only have to be precise about what we mean.

A WORKING DEFINITION: WHAT FAITH DECONSTRUCTION ACTUALLY MEANS

Deconstruction, as most people are using the word, is the experience of discovering a gap between the Christianity you were taught and the Christianity you find in Scripture

Three terms, then — three different things, routinely conflated, that have to be kept apart if any of this is going to make sense.

Deconstruction is the examination. It is what the word actually means, a disassembly that may or may not end in a rebuild, and the disassembly itself is neutral: some deconstruction ends in a stronger faith, some in a different faith, some in no faith at all. A faith that cannot survive honest examination was not going to survive anyway.

Deconversion is the conclusion that the faith is not true — and unlike deconstruction it is not a process but a landing. A person can deconstruct without ever deconverting, and a person can deconstruct and then deconvert, but the two are not interchangeable, because deconversion is a destination and deconstruction is the road that may or may not arrive there.

Renovation is the name for the healthy version, the thing that happens when a believer discovers that the house they were living in had structural problems, tears out the bad framing, and rebuilds on the original foundation. The foundation is Christ; the framing was the cultural assumptions they had mistaken for Christ. The house at the end of a renovation looks different from the

These three words matter because churches keep treating deconstruction as if it were deconversion, while deconstructors keep treating deconversion as if it were renovation — and both are category errors that cost people who did not have to be lost.

THE TWO MISREADINGS: GATEKEEPING THE QUESTIONER AND GLORIFYING ENDLESS DOUBT

Consider the pastor — and there are many — who has a young woman in his church begin to ask hard questions, reading widely and bringing him material he never encountered in seminary twenty years earlier, her questions not hostile but curious. He does what many pastors do: he tells her to be careful about what she is reading, that some of those authors reach dangerous conclusions, that the questions she is asking often end in people leaving the faith. He means all of it as shepherding; she hears all of it as gatekeeping, and within a year she is gone — not because of the books, but because of what the warning told her about the church, that it was a place where serious questions were met with nervous containment. She decided she needed a place where she could think.

At the moment of the warning she was not a deconverter, and she was not even a renovator yet; she was a first-year deconstructor with her hand on the examination tools, doing the very work the Bereans did. The pastor misread the phase, and his misreading cost the church a member — it may yet cost more.

THREE KINDS OF DECONSTRUCTOR: THE BEREAN, THE WOUNDED, AND THE DRIFT

If the response a person needs depends on what kind of deconstruction they are in, then the categories have to be named — and there are three of them, each requiring something the others do not.

The Berean is doing the work Paul commended: testing what they were taught against Scripture, reading primary sources, and often more biblically literate than the leaders worried about them. They do not need to be warned; they need a pastor who can keep up with them, because if their church cannot keep up they will find a church that can, or they will find a library that can — and the library does not come with accountability.

The Wounded was hurt by the church. This is the person who was told purity was the measure of their worth and has now spent a decade disentangling their sexuality from their shame; who was in a youth group where the

The Drift has gotten bored. Church went from a thing that made sense of their life to a thing that happened on Sunday mornings, and the questions they are now asking are not really questions at all — they are reasons, scaffolding for a decision that was made six months ago in their stomach. They are going to leave; in truth they already left. What they need is not answers but to be loved in a way that is not conditional on staying, and to be reminded that the door opens in both directions. Sometimes a Drift comes back, usually when they realize the world outside the church is not actually interested in their soul.

The categories are not rigid — a person can be a wounded Berean, and a Drift can become a wounded renovator after enough therapy — so they are diagnostic tools, not cages. The point is that the response a person needs depends on which category they are in, while the American church's default move is to treat every deconstructor either as a Drift who needs to be corralled or a Wounded person who needs to be told to forgive. The

A cardiologist who treats every chest pain as reflux will eventually kill someone. A church that treats every deconstructor the same way is killing something too. It is killing its own future.

**NOT AN ARGUMENT, A BROKEN TRUST:
WHY APOLOGETICS CANNOT FIX
DECONSTRUCTION**

One more thing, before we move to what they are actually leaving: deconstruction is not primarily an intellectual event, and that is the mistake the apologetics industry keeps making when it treats deconstruction as a debate to be won with better arguments. By the time most people are in deconstruction, the arguments have stopped doing the work they were designed to do — not because the arguments are weak, but because arguments do not repair trust, and the thing that has broken is trust.

The American church told its children some things — about Jesus, about Scripture, about holiness, about power — that do not hold up to examination. Some of what we told them is true and good and will outlast every critic; some of what we told them was cultural sediment we had mistaken for gospel. The children are old enough now to tell the difference, and they are asking us to tell them which is which. A church that cannot answer that question is not going to keep its children, and a church that answers it defensively is going to keep fewer.

This book is an attempt to answer it honestly. What they are actually leaving is the work of the next chapter.

CHAPTER TWO

What They Are Really Leaving

*What People Are Actually Leaving — Purity
Culture, Abuse Scandals, the Political Captivity of
the Church, the Prosperity Gospel, and a
Domesticated Jesus*

Most deconstruction is not about Jesus; it is about the package Jesus was sold inside, and anyone who wants to understand why people are walking out has to look hard at the package, because the package — not the risen Christ at the center of it — is what they are actually leaving.

A pastor's first instinct, when someone he loves begins to deconstruct, is to defend the essentials: he says the resurrection is true, that the Bible is true, that Jesus is Lord — and he is not wrong about any of it. But he is answering questions the deconstructor has not yet asked, because the person standing in front of him has not, in most cases, come to debate the resurrection; they have come to ask whether the church that teaches the resurrection has become something Jesus himself would

That is a different conversation entirely, and the pastor who answers the first question while the second one is being asked will watch the deconstructor leave the room wondering why no one in it could hear what they were actually saying. So it is worth naming, plainly and without flinching, what is being said.

THE PURITY CULTURE CATASTROPHE: HOW PURITY CULTURE DAMAGED A GENERATION

A generation of Christians — mostly but not only young women — were taught from the pulpit and the small group that their worth before God and before any future spouse could be measured by whether they had kissed anyone, held a hand past a certain line, or thought about someone in a way that crossed some unmarked threshold. They were told they were rose petals, that every touch was a petal lost, and that by the wedding there would be nothing left to give the groom if they had not guarded the petals; they were told that the way they dressed was a direct cause of other people's sin; they were handed rings and pledges at thirteen and told the ring had made them holy.

Then they grew up. Some reached marriage beds and could not function, because their bodies had spent a decade learning to associate desire with disgust; some divorced, because the men they married — raised on the same material — could not function either; some walked out of a marriage to a youth pastor who had groomed them at sixteen and discovered their church blaming them for the grooming. They read the Song of Songs in their thirties and realized the church had taught them the opposite of

THE SEXUAL ABUSE SCANDALS: WHY CHURCH COVER-UPS BROKE A GENERATION'S TRUST

They kept coming — Catholic first, then evangelical, then denomination after denomination: the Houston Chronicle investigation into the Southern Baptist Convention, the Ravi Zacharias revelations, the Hillsong collapse, the Mars Hill documentary, the rolling list of pastors with hidden second lives and the elders who covered for them. It was not one story but a pattern, and the pattern had a shape that became hard to unsee once it came into focus: the institution protects itself. When it must choose between a victim and a celebrity, it chooses the celebrity; between transparency and the brand, the brand; between the abused and the donor, the donor.

A generation watched this happen in slow motion and asked the question no one wants spoken aloud — if the institution is this willing to protect itself at the cost of the vulnerable, why assume it is telling the truth about God? That is the corrosive question, and it is worth being precise about it, because it is not a question about God at all; it is a question about the institution's reliability as a witness. And a witness whose reliability has collapsed cannot restore it by shouting louder about the message — it can only restore it by telling the truth about itself and paying the cost. Most institutions will not pay the cost. So they lose the witness.

THE POLITICAL CAPTIVITY OF THE

This is the one pastors hate most, which is reason to be careful with it and no reason at all to be soft. There is a version of American Christianity that has become indistinguishable from a political tribe — it has a preferred party, a preferred leader, and a preferred set of enemies; it baptizes those preferences with language borrowed from the pulpit; it implies, and sometimes says openly, that a Christian who votes differently is not really a Christian; it meets public sin in its own tribe with silence or excuse and public sin in the other tribe with prophetic outrage. For many watching, it has become impossible to tell apart from cable news with a cross on it.

Pastors vote, and they hold opinions about policy they could defend with Scripture and reason; the point is not that Christians should have no political views. The point is sharper than that. When an entire generation of young people watched their parents' church endorse, defend, and excuse conduct from a politician that the same church would have disciplined a deacon for, they learned something they could not unlearn — that the church's professed ethics were not real ethics but tribal markers, ethics that bent the moment the tribe needed them to bend. A young person raised to take the sermons seriously will not take them seriously again once they have seen this; they may keep attending for a while, but they will not believe the sermons.

When politics becomes the lens through

This is not a left-wing point. There are progressive versions of the same captivity — churches that have let their politics rewrite their theology exactly as thoroughly as conservative churches have — and the captivity itself is the problem, not the direction it leans. When Scripture becomes a resource pool for the tribe, young people can smell it from a hundred yards, and they are leaving because they can smell it.

THE PROSPERITY GOSPEL AND ITS SOFTER COUSINS: THE FAITH THAT BREAKS AT THE WALL

The hard version is obvious — seed your faith, plant your money, claim your healing, buy the pastor a jet — and most readers already see through it. The softer cousins are more dangerous precisely because they are more plausible: they appear as preaching that treats Jesus mainly as a resource for a better life, as worship songs that sing of God as a romantic partner whose job is to reassure, as ministry that measures success by attendance and giving rather than by cruciformity, and most quietly of all as the pervasive, mostly unconscious assumption that faith is supposed to make life work. When life does not

Many of the people walking out have hit a wall their faith was never built to contain — a miscarriage, a divorce they did not want, a child with a diagnosis, a cancer that does not respond. They turned to a faith they were told would work and discovered that the version they had been handed has no theology for the wall. The New Testament does. Paul wrote Philippians from prison, and the theme of the letter is joy; James opened his letter to believers with a hard command:

Count it all joy, my brothers, when you meet trials of various kinds.

— JAMES 1:2

Job sat on the ash heap, refused to curse God, and was declared righteous. The Christian faith carries an enormous theology of suffering, and the American church has mostly traded it for a theology of breakthrough — so when the wall meets the breakthrough theology, the breakthrough theology shatters, and the person concludes that Christianity has failed. What has failed is a sub-Christian substitute.

THE DOMESTICATION OF JESUS: THE GAP BETWEEN THE GOSPELS AND THE PULPIT

This one is quieter, and it runs underneath all the others. At some point the Jesus who flipped the tables in the temple, called the religious experts whitewashed tombs, stood before a hostile crowd and named their hypocrisy, wept over the city that had killed its prophets,

The result is a Jesus who fits comfortably in the living room. He threatens no one. He asks nothing that costs the middle class anything; he never stands on the side of the poor in a way that would embarrass a donor; he can be endorsed by a candidate, printed on a coffee mug, and quoted on the back of a merchandise tee. He is not the Jesus of the Gospels — and young people are leaving the domesticated Jesus because once you have read the Gospels for yourself you cannot unsee the gap.

BIBLICAL ILLITERACY DRESSED AS BIBLICAL FAITHFULNESS: WHEN THE READERS CAUGHT UP

A movement that loves the Bible and does not read it is a movement in trouble. Across the American church, from the pew to the pulpit, the Bible is cited constantly and engaged rarely — a person can attend an evangelical church for twenty years and never have worked through a single book of it slowly, in context, with the flow of the argument intact. They hear verses; they do not read books. They memorize proof-texts for positions; they do not sit

The young people asking the hard questions have, in many cases, started reading the Bible for themselves, and what they have found there is stranger, stronger, and more disruptive than what the church taught them it said: they have discovered that the proof-texts were often ripped out of contexts that say nearly the opposite, that the verses they were told were obvious are, read slowly, deeply contested, and that the people who told them the Bible clearly says this or that had not read the surrounding chapters recently — or had never read them at all — and were repeating a tradition dressed as exegesis. This is catastrophic, because it means the church lost its authority the moment the reader caught up. And the readers have caught up.

And then there is the thing that turns deconstructing believers into departing ones more reliably than any other item on the list: the response to the critics. When they raise any of these concerns they are met with defensiveness rather than repentance — told they are being divisive, told they are a threat, told they have drifted into worldly categories, told their generation is characterized by doubt, told to submit more and think less. The institution circles the wagons.

For the Berean and the Wounded alike, this is the final signal: the institution cannot self-correct, because it has tied its identity to its own infallibility — and a person cannot grow inside an institution that cannot be wrong. So they leave.

That is the list, and it does not deserve softening; all of it is real, and all of it is happening. A church that wants to respond has to begin by admitting that the critique is not

No pastor gets to stand above this list, and the honest ones know it. Over fifteen years many of us have defended from the pulpit positions we would not defend now, and answered a deconstructor's question with a defensiveness that was about protecting the institution rather than shepherding the soul; to name the list is to confess a share in it. Nobody in American ministry is exempt.

To the deconstructor reading this: at least some pastors are aware the list is real and are trying to do something about it. To the pastor reading this: welcome to the discomfort. The next chapter is about why the church keeps missing what is actually being said — and how to stop.

CHAPTER THREE

Why the Church Keeps Missing It

*How Pastors and Parents Misread Deconstruction
— the Six Reflexes That Drive People Out and How
to Stop Them*

There is a particular conversation that happens between a pastor and someone deconstructing their faith, and any pastor who has lasted long enough has been in it more than once: the deconstructor says something honest, the pastor hears something threatening, and from that first misfire the whole exchange bends out of true. The pastor answers the thing he heard, and the deconstructor — hearing a man who did not hear them — says it again, louder, while the pastor, still registering threat and not grief, answers with more force. Then the deconstructor leaves. The pastor tells the elders the person was never really open to correction, the elders nod, and the next deconstructor walks in to begin the cycle again.

The miss keeps happening, and the point of this chapter is that it can be stopped. What follows is aimed at

THE DEFENSIVE CROUCH AND THE TRIBAL SLOT: WHY DEFENDING THE CHURCH FIRST DRIVES PEOPLE OUT

The first reflex is to defend. When someone criticizes the church, a pastor's trained response — honed over a decade of culture-war formation — is to explain why the criticism is not fair, and while that is sometimes the right move, it is almost never the first one. What the deconstructor sets on the table, in many cases, is not a debate but a grief: they are mourning the loss of a simpler faith, the discovery that something they trusted was not, in the end, trustworthy. A pastor who rushes to defend the institution has refused to grieve with them, and that refusal is a choice the person reads correctly. Not a neutral one. A pastor who cannot grieve is a pastor standing with the institution and not with the sheep.

The pastoral move is to grieve first; the defense, if it is warranted at all, can come later, in another conversation, after trust has been rebuilt — but the grief cannot be skipped. When Jesus stood over Jerusalem and wept, he was not defending the temple; he was mourning the city. A pastor who cannot mourn the American church cannot be trusted to speak truthfully about it.

The second reflex is to file the deconstructor under an enemy tribe — the critic who names political captivity

The slot is almost always wrong, because real deconstructors do not map cleanly onto political tribes. A young woman wounded by purity culture may be more theologically conservative than her pastor; a young man grieving the abuse scandals may carry no progressive politics at all; a young mother who watched her church rally around a candidate may be a confessional Christian who simply noticed that her tradition had been handed over to be used as a mascot. The moment you put the person in the slot, you have stopped seeing the person.

The discipline, then, is to listen long enough to discover that the one in front of you is not the caricature in your head — which takes far more than the five minutes at the coffee table after the service. Schedule the coffee, drink it slowly, and ask three follow-up questions before saying anything declarative. A shepherd who will not look at a sheep long enough to recognize it is not shepherding anything.

ANSWERING THE QUESTION THAT WAS NOT ASKED: THE QUESTION UNDERNEATH THE QUESTION

The third reflex belongs to apologetics. The pastor is trained to have answers, so when a question comes he

So the question sounds like this: are the Gospels historically reliable? The pastor has the answer ready, and he talks about the early manuscripts, the multiple independent attestations, the criterion of embarrassment — all of it correct, and none of it relevant, because the question underneath the question was never about historicity at all. It was whether the pastor could be trusted to tell the truth about what the Gospels actually say, given that this same pastor had, six months earlier, used a Gospel text to defend something the deconstructor now believes is indefensible. The real question was not, is it real. The real question was, can you be trusted to read it honestly — and that answer is nowhere in the apologetics textbook.

*The question underneath the question
is rarely the one the textbook
anticipated. The humility to ask what
it is, not the knowledge to answer what
it isn't, is the discipline.*

So learn to ask what lies underneath, and the way to

THE SOLUTION SERMON AND THE SLIPPERY-SLOPE PANIC: WHY FEAR OF DOUBT BACKFIRES

The fourth reflex is the urge to fix. The pastor reaches for the sermon he would preach with thirty minutes and a pulpit and delivers a compressed version of it at the coffee table, certain the whole time that he is helping — but the deconstructor is not in the market for a sermon. They have had sermons. They came precisely because the sermons stopped landing, and what they wanted was to sit with a human being who could set the sermon down.

A compressed sermon at the coffee table is the pastoral equivalent of handing a grieving widow a pamphlet on the stages of grief: the information may be accurate, and it is still the wrong thing in that moment. What she needs is someone to sit down and not talk for a minute, and the deconstructor needs exactly the same — a person who can be present without needing to produce something. Presence comes before solution, and the order is not decoration. The order is the whole thing.

The test is simple. Can you hold a thirty-minute conversation with a deconstructor in which you tell them nothing — in which you only ask, reflect back what they said, acknowledge what is true, and stay with what is hard — so that by the end they feel more heard than in any previous conversation on the subject in their life? Fail that

The fifth reflex is fear. The pastor watches a person begin to ask serious questions, projects forward to the worst version of where those questions might lead, and once that worst case is lodged in his head every conversation afterward is with the worst case and not the person. He warns them away from books they have already read, he implies their direction ends in apostasy, and he mentions — in a tone meant to be gentle and failing — that he has seen this go badly before.

The person hears it accurately: the pastor is afraid of them, and once they hear the fear they know this is not a man they can be honest with. So they begin to protect him from their real questions, handing him the sanitized version, and he feels reassured because the sanitized version is manageable — while the relationship quietly becomes a performance and the real thinking happens somewhere else, somewhere that may not have their soul's best interest in mind. The pastor has driven them into less trustworthy company by being unable to bear the real questions himself. That is the cost of the flinch.

The discipline is to stay in the room with the worst version of the question, so that when a person says, I am not sure I believe the resurrection anymore, the answer is, tell me more — said without flinching. And that requires believing, deep in the bones, that the resurrection is strong enough to survive being examined out loud. Where that belief is missing, the problem is not the deconstructor. The problem is the pastor's own faith, and it must be repaired before he tries to repair anyone else's.

WHEN THE COMMUNITY TREATS DOUBT

The sixth reflex is the hardest to admit, because it is so often done and so rarely named: when a person's deconstruction becomes public, or merely known, the community begins to treat them as contagious. Other members are quietly warned to be careful around them, small group goes stilted, and the deconstructor notices — they always notice. They experience it as social exile because that is exactly what it is, and when they leave, the leaving gets attributed to their unbelief, when in truth it was catalyzed by a community that treated questions as a threat to be contained rather than a soul to be carried.

The early church had a different posture. Thomas doubted the resurrection in public, and a week later Jesus appeared and offered his wounds for inspection.



Put your finger here; see my hands. Reach out your hand and put it into my side. Stop doubting and believe.

— JOHN 20:27

Jesus did not shame Thomas, did not exile him, did not warn the other disciples about him; he gave Thomas access to the evidence and trusted the evidence to do its work — and Thomas came through. If Jesus could bear Thomas, a small group can bear the young mother with hard questions.

It is hard because it costs something, and the costs are real: it costs the pastor his certainty that he is automatically in the right, it costs the community its sense that its boundaries are clean, and it costs the institution

THE DISCIPLINE OF SHUTTING UP: LEARNING TO LISTEN BEFORE YOU ANSWER

Consider, then, how the conversation can go when the reflexes are set aside. A woman comes to her pastor to say she is done; she has a list of reasons, some he agrees with and some he does not, and he has spent the entire week preparing a careful response in case she asks for one — arguments ready, verses ready, a pastoral plan laid out.

She sits down and begins to tell him her reasons, and somewhere in the middle of them she starts to cry — not performatively, not strategically, but the way a person cries when they have held something for a long time and finally let it go. The pastoral question in that moment is whether the plan can be set down, and so the arguments go undelivered. The only true thing to say is, I am so sorry, and then, I should have seen this sooner, and then nothing at all for a while. She cries for another ten minutes. Then she says thank you, and that she needs some time, and then she leaves.

Sometimes she comes back — not right away, but months later, in a different seat than she used to take, reading the Bible more carefully than the pastor does, her questions sharper than before and her faith stronger than it has ever been. None of that is the pastor's doing. What he did, in the one right moment, was shut up; had he obeyed his first three reflexes, he would have lost her.

Most deconstruction conversations will not go that well,

CHAPTER FOUR

The Bible the Critics Found

*Is the Bible Reliable? An Honest Look at
Manuscripts, the Canon, Old Testament Violence,
Bible Contradictions, and the Hard Texts the
Critics Raise*

There is a version of the Bible handed out in Sunday school, and there is a version atheists describe on YouTube, and neither one is quite the Bible — because the actual book is stranger, older, and more disruptive than either party wants to admit, and a person in deconstruction who picks it up honestly is, for the first time, in a fair fight with it. That fight is where this chapter lives.

What follows walks through the hardest places the critics have found and tells the truth about each one. Some of their points are good, and the church has not answered them well; others dissolve the moment one stops reading the Bible with the assumptions of a twenty-first-century American and starts reading it with the assumptions of the

THE MANUSCRIPTS AND THE CANON: HAS THE BIBLE BEEN CHANGED, AND WHO CHOSE THE BOOKS?

The critic says the Bible has been copied so many times that no one can know what it originally said, and because that version is the one filling a sixteen-year-old's feed, it feels devastating — yet on closer inspection it turns out to be the weakest argument in the skeptic's arsenal.

The New Testament is, by orders of magnitude, the best-attested document of the ancient world — earlier manuscripts, more manuscripts, and more geographically distributed manuscripts than any comparable ancient text — and where there are variants, and there are many, the overwhelming majority are spelling differences, word-order changes, and scribal adjustments that never touch meaning. The places where a variant actually bears on doctrine can be counted on two hands, and even there the doctrine is defended from dozens of other texts. The manuscript argument is a bogeyman. A sixty-minute honest look at the data ends it.

The Old Testament tells a more interesting story. When the Dead Sea Scrolls surfaced, they revealed a Hebrew Bible that was, with only minor variation, the same one in use now, a thousand years older than the copies anyone had previously held — a stunning vindication of textual stability. But the Scrolls also showed different textual

Then comes the canon. The critic says the Bible was decided by a council of politically motivated men who picked winners and excluded losers — the popular version is Dan Brown, and the scholarly version is more sophisticated and more wrong — but there was never a moment at which a committee sat down with a pile of equally authoritative documents and voted. The four Gospels were recognized across the church within a century of Jesus, because of their apostolic connections and because the church that received them recognized their voice, and the alleged alternative Gospels make the case for the canon by themselves. The Gospel of Thomas is a collection of sayings, some close to the canonical Gospels and some wildly divergent, with no coherent narrative or moral architecture; the Gospel of Peter has a talking cross. These are not suppressed truths. They are transparently later and transparently derivative.

What the church did with the canon is what a family does with photographs: not every picture taken of a grandmother goes in the album, and the ones that go in are the ones the family recognizes, while the ones that do not are not suppressed but simply not claimed. The authoritative claim is communal and retrospective, made by the people who know the face.

This one is harder. The critic points at the conquest of Canaan and asks how a loving God could command the slaughter of entire populations, and the easy answers taught in youth group will not hold.

It will not do to say the Canaanites were all wicked and deserved it, because the text includes infants; and it will not do to say it was a different dispensation, because a God who changed his ethics could not be trusted on his current ones. The question is real, and it deserves real engagement.

Here is what a careful reading shows. The conquest narratives are written in the language of the ancient Near East, where hyperbole in war reporting was a standard literary convention — a king would say he utterly destroyed a city and then, three chapters later, describe capturing the same city again — and the ancient reader knew the convention and knew how to read it, while the modern reader, untrained in the genre, reads it flat and recoils. The texts are also clear that the Canaanites had been given time to repent, since Genesis tells Abraham that the iniquity of the Amorites is not yet complete and will not be for four hundred years. The judgment was not arbitrary. It was the end of a long patience.

 *The iniquity of the Amorites is not yet complete.*

— GENESIS 15:16

And the very standard that brings judgment on the Canaanites brings judgment on Israel a few centuries later, when Israel becomes Canaanite in its behavior — which

None of this removes the difficulty. The text is hard, and it is supposed to be hard. But the critic who treats the violence passages as proof that the biblical God is a monster has not wrestled with the text; he has skimmed it looking for ammunition, while the reader who has actually worked through Walter Moberly or Paul Copan or Greg Boyd — even where they disagree on the details — knows there is a conversation underway that the YouTube caricature never represents. The critic's argument lands with force only against a version of the Bible that serious readers gave up on long ago.

*What has failed the tests is not the text.
It is the packaging.*

THE CONTRADICTIONS AND THE AUTHORSHIP QUESTIONS: BIBLE CONTRADICTIONS AND EYEWITNESS TESTIMONY

The critic lists alleged contradictions: the Gospels give different numbers of angels at the tomb, the crucifixion accounts seem to place the event on different days, and Paul's Damascus-road story is told three times in Acts with different details.

Each one is either an apparent discrepancy that

The authorship questions follow the same shape. The critic says Moses did not write the Pentateuch, that the Gospels were written decades after Jesus by people who never met him, that many of Paul's letters were forged under his name — and each claim has a kernel of real scholarship with a mountain of overclaim piled on top. The Pentateuch is clearly edited, and that is visible in the text itself, but it does not follow that the edited text is unreliable. The Gospels were written within a generation of the events, by or in connection with the eyewitnesses, in a culture where oral transmission was astonishingly stable; that they were written down after the fact is not a problem but the norm for ancient history. And the disputed Pauline letters are, in the judgment of many serious scholars, genuinely Pauline, while the arguments against them rest on stylistic assumptions that cannot bear the weight placed on them.

The critic has, in many cases, accepted the most skeptical version of critical scholarship as if it were settled fact, when the actual situation is far more contested — and a reader who has worked through Richard Bauckham on

THE HARD TEXTS AND THE LOAD-BEARING GREEK: SEXUALITY, SCRIPTURE, AND WHAT METANOIA REALLY MEANS

On sexuality and gender, where many deconstructors are most concerned, the honest answer is narrow: the texts say what they say, and the historic church read them the way it did because that is what they say.

The revisionist readings, charitable as some of them are, require theological moves that, applied consistently, dissolve the authority of Scripture itself — because the method that rescues those texts can rescue any text from any claim. The question is not whether the traditional reading is cruel; it is whether the text is actually saying what the traditional reading has said, and in most cases it is. The pastoral response has often been cruel, and that is a separate and serious failure. But the text is not on the revisionist's side. That is uncomfortable to read. It was not written to be comfortable.

One example shows how a single Greek word can change the whole argument, standing in for a dozen the deconstructor will meet. The word *metanoia* is usually translated repentance, and most people hear repentance and think of guilt, contrition, groveling — but the word does not mean that. It is a compound: *meta* is a preposition meaning after, or across, or with, and *noia* comes from *nous*, mind, so that *metanoia* means

Jesus did not stand by the Jordan and tell people to feel worse; he told them the kingdom of God was at hand and their minds needed to rearrange — a different gospel call than much American preaching has delivered. A deconstructor who was told that Christian faith is about feeling adequately guilty meets a different faith when he meets the actual word: a faith that asks for a reorientation of the whole mental architecture. That is harder than feeling bad. It is also far more freeing.

THE FAITHFUL RESPONSE: READING DEEPER INSTEAD OF DEFENDING

There is more. There is always more. The point is not to produce an apologetic tract that answers every question, but to name what is true.

Which is this. The Bible the critics have found is, in places, genuinely strange, genuinely hard, and genuinely different from what American Christianity has preached — and it is also, on careful reading, genuinely what it claims to be: a text that bears the weight of examination, that pushes back on every attempt to conscript it into a human agenda, left or right, ancient or modern, a text that still, after four thousand years of readers trying to domesticate it, refuses to be domesticated.

The faithful response to the Bible the critics found is not defense. It is deeper reading. The Bereans did not defend Paul; they examined what he said against Scripture, and the church is asked to do the same with its inheritance — for if the inheritance survives the

The Jesus under the brand is the next thing to find. He has been under there the whole time.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Jesus Who Was Buried Under the Brand

*The Jesus of the Gospels Versus the American Jesus
— Recovering the Confronting, Grieving,
Crucified, and Risen Christ the Brand Edited Out*

Read the Gospels for a month — only the Gospels, with no commentary beside them and no sermon in the ear — Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John, straight through and slowly, as though the story were arriving for the first time. At the end of the month the question is simple: is the man in those four books the same man preached most Sundays of one's life? For most American Christians who have run the experiment honestly, the answer is no.

The Jesus of the Gospels is not rude for its own sake, but he is not smooth either; he is confrontational with the religious professionals and tender with prostitutes and tax collectors in the same breath. He breaks the Sabbath

The gentleness is not the error. Jesus did welcome children, he did feed the crowds, he did forgive sinners, and the tenderness in him is real, not invented; the error is amputation. The American church did not manufacture the gentle Jesus — it cut everything else away and kept the gentleness as the whole, and a Jesus who is only gentle is a Jesus no one would trouble to crucify. The cross requires a man who threatened powerful people with something real, real enough that they decided he had to die. That man is not on the mug. He was edited out.

THE JESUS THE BRAND COULD NOT SELL: WHEN THE CROWD WALKED AWAY IN JOHN 6

John 6 is among the most telling chapters in the Gospels, because it shows him losing the room on purpose. Jesus feeds the five thousand, the crowd ignites and moves to make him king by force, and he withdraws; and the next day, when they track him down, he preaches a sermon engineered to thin them out — they must eat his flesh and drink his blood, he says — and the text records the result without softening it:



– JOHN 6:66

This is not a marketing strategy, not a megachurch playbook; it is a prophet refusing to let the crowd's enthusiasm rewrite his message. The American church, which counts attendance as the proof of God's favor, does not know what to do with this Jesus, and it has quietly shown him the door.

Then there is the Jesus who indicts the religious establishment — and to feel the weight of him you have to read Matthew 23 aloud and listen to the rhythm of it. Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites, seven times over: you shut the kingdom of heaven in people's faces; you cross sea and land to make one convert and make him twice the child of hell you are; you tithe mint and dill and cumin and have left undone the weightier matters of the law, justice and mercy and faithfulness; you are whitewashed tombs, beautiful outside and full of dead men's bones within. This is the Jesus the domestication has removed, the one who would not fit easily behind the pulpit of many churches that wear his name — to most of them he would be the guest speaker the elder board gently advises against inviting back.

And there is the Jesus who stands with the margins. He touches lepers, which the law said would defile him, and instead of defiling him the touch heals them; he talks with a Samaritan woman at a well in the open day, which no respectable rabbi would have done; he receives a woman caught in adultery, refuses to let her accusers stone her, and tells her to go and sin no more. Both halves are him —

The American church has tended to keep one half and discard the other: the progressive version keeps the mercy and drops the moral clarity, while the conservative version keeps the moral clarity and drops the mercy — or keeps a performance of mercy that vanishes the instant it would cost the community anything. Neither version is Jesus. Jesus is both, always, at the same moment, and he is embarrassed by neither.

THE PARABLES WERE LANDMINES: WHAT THE PRODIGAL SON AND THE GOOD SAMARITAN ACTUALLY MEANT

The parable of the prodigal son is not chiefly about the prodigal; it is about the older brother, and the punchline is not the party but the father leaving the party to plead with the son who stayed home and resented everyone who came back. Jesus told that story to Pharisees, not to prodigals — so the domesticated reading, which has the Pharisees cheering the welcome of the younger son, gets it exactly backward, because the parable is aimed straight at their chest. They are the older brother. He is telling them they are the ones who will not come in.

Read as they were delivered, to the audiences who first heard them, most of the parables are not cozy moral tales but kingdom landmines. The good Samaritan is told to a lawyer who wanted to know who counted as his neighbor, and the answer is that the ethnic enemy is the neighbor and the one who refuses to act on it is no better than the priest and the Levite who walked past; the workers in the vineyard is a story about grace that offends the laborers

Undomesticated, each parable is a trap set for a particular hearer — and the hearer is usually the one in the front pew. Including the one in the pulpit.

Domesticated, each becomes a vague lesson about being kind, and that is the cost of the edit: the story built to detonate under the religious is repackaged as a greeting card for the comfortable.

THE JESUS WHO CRIES: GRIEF, LAZARUS, AND A GOD WHO WEEPS

John 11 gives us the shortest verse in the English Bible, and it arrives at the moment you would least expect it — Lazarus is dead, and Jesus, who knows he is about to raise him, does not skip the grief:

| *Jesus wept.*

— JOHN 11:35

The tears are not a performance, not practice grief; they are the grief of God at a world that contains a word like dead. Jesus weeps because his friend is dead, because his friends are broken, because death itself is an enemy he

This is not the Jesus who tells the bereaved to count their blessings. This is the Jesus who weeps with a couple over a miscarriage, holds a hand through chemotherapy, and stands at a grandmother's funeral, whose presence does not erase the loss but refuses to let the loss have the last word. The American church has at times been so afraid of grief that it told its members not to feel it — an instruction that was never in the Bible, but came instead from the culture that had colonized it.

THE JESUS WHO DIES ON PURPOSE: WHAT THE ATONEMENT IS AND IS NOT

The crucifixion, in the Gospels, is not an accident, not something that merely happened to Jesus; he walks into the trap with his eyes open:

*When the days drew near for him to be taken up, he
set his face to go to Jerusalem.*

— LUKE 9:51

He tells the disciples in advance what is coming; he prays at Gethsemane not to escape the cross but for the strength to bear it; he goes silent before Pilate, because there is nothing left to say to a man already convicted by his own cowardice. Then he dies, slowly, in public, for the people who had cheered his death days earlier, for people not yet born, for people reading this page.

THE JESUS WHO ROSE: WHY THE RESURRECTION IS THE HINGE OF EVERYTHING

The resurrection is the hinge of everything: without it the Christian faith is a touching ethical tradition with an inspiring founder, no more binding than any other, while with it everything else follows. The earliest Christians did not announce the resurrection as a metaphor — they announced it as a historical claim, that they had eaten fish with him, and they died for it. Not for the ethics, not for the community, but for the claim that a particular man had walked out of a particular tomb on a particular morning, and that they had seen him.

The deconstructor has to do something with the resurrection. He can deny it, in which case Christianity is false and all the labor of reforming it is wasted, because what is not true cannot be reformed; or he can accept it, in which case everything else stands downstream of that

If Christ has not been raised, our preaching is useless and so is your faith. More than that, we are then found to be false witnesses about God.

— 1 CORINTHIANS 15:14-15

Paul did not believe the faith could survive without the resurrection. Neither should we.

WHAT IS UNDER THE PAINT: THE CHRIST WORTH FOLLOWING AFTER DISILLUSIONMENT

This is the weight to carry out of the chapter: the Jesus of the Gospels is worth following, and in American Christianity he has been painted over by a Jesus easier to market — so that to lose faith in the marketed Jesus may be exactly the loss that frees a person to find the other one.

A deconstruction that strips the paint and reveals the original wood is not a loss of faith but a restoration, because what lies under the paint is stranger and stronger than anyone was told. The Jesus who wept at Lazarus's tomb, drove out the moneychangers, ate with Matthew, and walked toward Jerusalem with his face set is a person worth loving, even now, at the end of a long disillusionment. He is not nervous about anyone's doubts. He has seen worse.

The next chapter is about the history that was never

CHAPTER SIX

The History the Youth Group Did Not Teach

*An Honest Church History — Crusades, Slavery,
the Inquisition, and Civil Rights, and Why the
Whole Record Is Stronger Than the Scandal Reel*

Most American Christians received church history not as a story but as a charge sheet — in pieces, somewhere between high school and college, usually read aloud in the mouth of a critic — and the indictment runs the same way every time: the church invented itself at Nicaea as a political instrument of Rome, then burned witches, ran the Inquisition, blessed the crusades, defended slavery, and fought science at every turn, with some charity scattered along the way, mostly as cover for the rest. And here we are.

That version is not nothing; each item in it carries some truth at its core, and the honest thing is to say so before saying anything else. The problem is that it is the scandal reel of two thousand years played as though it were the whole film. A church lived every single day of those two millennia, and most of what happened in those

The honest history is not a defense, because the sins are real and they matter; it is the whole thing, as nearly as a chapter can hold it, told this way precisely because the whole thing is stronger than the edited version. Tom Holland — who is not a Christian — wrote a seven-hundred-page book called *Dominion* that presses a case Christian historians have made for a long time and American Christians have rarely heard: that the moral assumptions the modern West treats as universal and obvious are neither universal nor obvious. They are Christian. They were not common in the ancient world before Christianity, and they would not survive the death of Christian culture — which means the critics who wield those assumptions to indict the church are standing, without noticing it, on a moral platform the church built.

That is not an argument that Christianity is true. It is an argument for being fair to the record — a record that includes the crusades and the hospitals both, and hands you no version where you get one without the other.

THE EARLY CHURCH: WHO CHRISTIANS WERE BEFORE THEY HAD POWER

Start here, because this is the period the critic imagines as either a purer time the later church betrayed or a fiction the later church invented — and it is neither.

For its first three centuries, before it held any political power at all, the church was a mostly urban, mostly poor, mostly mixed movement of Jews and Gentiles who met in

THE IMPERIAL CHURCH: CONSTANTINE AND THE COST OF POWER

When Constantine converted and Christianity became first a permitted and then a privileged religion, something shifted, and that shift has fed centuries of argument that have not yet settled.

Some of it was good. The persecution stopped, the church could build in the open, and for the first time the emperor could be held to account by ecclesial voices — at least in theory; when Ambrose stood up to Theodosius, a moral weight entered the world that had not existed in it before. And some of it was disastrous, because the church took up the instruments of the state, began to coerce belief, and started measuring itself by size and influence rather than by the shape of the cross. The Constantinian

The honest believer need not defend every imperial move; Augustine, for one, made arguments for coercing the Donatists that most Christians today rightly reject. That does not mean Augustine is discarded. It means he was a man writing inside a particular political moment, and one can honor his best work while refusing his worst — which is exactly the reading every great thinker demands. The critic who treats each historical Christian failure as proof the whole tradition is worthless is applying a standard he would extend to no one else: he does not cancel the Enlightenment for Voltaire's antisemitism, and he does not cancel Greek philosophy for Aristotle's defense of slavery. Hold the same standard, or hold none. But do not aim it in one direction only.

THE MEDIEVAL PERIOD: THE CRUSADES, THE UNIVERSITIES, AND WHAT THE CRITICS MISS

The period the critic raises most often is the one he knows least. Yes, there were crusades — but they were not a single event, and the difference is the whole point.

The crusades were a complicated, multi-century series of military campaigns driven by a tangle of motives — some genuinely religious, some political, some economic, and some plainly sinful — and they will not collapse into a slogan. Some were defensive answers to real aggression; some were offensive, and a few of those committed atrocities that contemporary Christians condemned at the time. When the crusaders sacked Constantinople in 1204,

And the same medieval church that launched those campaigns also built the universities that eventually produced the very scientists the critic celebrates, preserved the classical texts through the collapse of Rome, and produced Thomas Aquinas, whose holding-together of faith and reason has not been bettered in eight hundred years. It produced Francis of Assisi, whose poverty and gentleness reshaped the moral imagination of a continent; it produced hospitals, the first theories of international law, the first serious accounts of a just war, and the monasteries where women could read, write, and govern themselves in ways secular life flatly forbade them. The critic who keeps the crusades and discards all of that is not reading the period. He is scoring a point.

THE REFORMATION: RENEWAL, RELIGIOUS WARS, AND THE ROOTS OF RELIGIOUS FREEDOM

This one runs closer to home, because most American Christians, whether they know it or not, are its heirs.

The Reformation was not simple and never resolved into a tidy moral. It was a multi-generational fracturing of the Western church, driven all at once by genuine theological renewal, real ecclesial corruption, the rise of national politics, a new communications technology in the printing press, and several strong personalities who did not much like one another. Luther's convictions about justification by grace through faith recovered something

The wars of religion that followed killed a great many people, and they also clarified, eventually, that coercion in matters of conscience was a road the church could not keep walking. The principle of religious freedom, which the secular critic usually credits to the Enlightenment alone, was hammered out in large part by Christians sickened by what happened when Christians tried to force one another's consciences — by Roger Williams, who founded Rhode Island as a project of religious liberty, and by William Penn, who did the same with Pennsylvania. These were Christian works, grounded in Christian conviction, and they became the very ground on which the secular critic now stands to object.

THE QUESTION OF SLAVERY: HOW CHRISTIANS DEFENDED IT AND HOW CHRISTIANS ENDED IT

This is the hardest one, and it will not be softened: Christians defended slavery in the American South using the Bible, chapter and verse.

That defense was no minor footnote. It was a large, sophisticated, well-resourced theological project — with seminary professors and denominational statements and pamphlets distributed by the thousands — and it was wrong, a spectacular failure of exegesis in service of an economic and cultural interest the exegetes refused to examine. The abolitionists, many of them also Christians,

That the wrong side eventually lost the argument does not erase the damage it did, and Black Americans whose ancestors were enslaved owe no gratitude that the abolitionists finally prevailed. The church's part in slavery is a wound the American church has still not fully reckoned with, and the deconstructor leaving over the race question is seeing a real failure, not imagining one. The right answer is not to point at Wilberforce and call the matter settled; the right answer is to examine, to repent, and to make restitution in whatever forms the situation requires — work the church has begun in some places and has a long way still to go in most.

But here is what the critic misses, and it is not a small thing. The framework that finally defeated slavery was itself a Christian framework — the claim that every human being bears the image of God, that there is neither slave nor free in Christ, that the poor are blessed and the meek will inherit the earth. That was the crowbar. The abolitionists were not stepping outside Christianity to oppose slavery; they were stepping further inside it than the slaveholders had ever dared. The slaveholders had the surface. The abolitionists had the core.

*The long arc of moral correction
within the church's story is not a
refutation of the story. It is the story —
the slow working out of a seed planted*

THE CIVIL RIGHTS MOVEMENT: THE CHRISTIAN ENGINE BEHIND THE MARCH

The movement that dismantled American legal segregation was, at its center, a Christian movement — and that is not a flattering reading imposed after the fact, but the plain shape of the thing.

Martin Luther King, Jr. was not a secular humanist borrowing religious language for effect; he was a Baptist minister whose theology was the engine of his ethics. The Southern Christian Leadership Conference was Southern and Christian and led by ministers, the marchers sang church hymns, and the strategy itself — nonviolent resistance — was rooted in the Sermon on the Mount and the suffering servant of Isaiah. The moral authority that moved a nation came straight out of the tradition the critic now dismisses as past saving.

Both things are true at once, and the honesty is in holding them together. The American church, in aggregate, was disgracefully silent or actively complicit through the civil rights era — King wrote his letter from the Birmingham jail in part to rebuke the white pastors who counseled patience — and that same American church, through particular men and women and particular congregations, produced the very movement that forced the change. The simple story, Christianity the oppressor

That pattern — a church called back to itself by its own best voices — is the shape of the honest story, and it repeats: it is how slavery was ended, how segregation was dismantled, how the medieval church reformed itself more than once, and how the early church held together through persecution at all. A tradition capable of self-correction is a living tradition. A tradition that only ever defends itself is dead.

The American church is now being asked to self-correct on several fronts at once — abuse, political captivity, racial reckoning, gender and power, biblical illiteracy — and many of the deconstructors are precisely the voices calling it back to itself. Not all of them are right, and not all of their proposals are wise; but the posture, the willingness to name the failure in public and ask for better, is exactly what has, historically, kept the tradition alive. Scripture has always made room for that voice:



*Let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness
like an ever-flowing stream.*

— AMOS 5:24

A church that listens to its own prophets, even when the prophets are angry, is a church with a future; a church that only hunts its prophets down will not have one. The path through the questions begins there — not around them, but through them — and what rebuilt faith actually looks like, what it does not look like, and why those who have reached it call the cost worth paying is the work of

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Path Through

*How to Work Through Deconstruction With Faith
Intact — Seven Disciplines for Reading the
Sources, Sitting With Doubt, and Staying in
Community*

There is no program for this. The terrain can be described, but the road cannot be paved in advance, because it has to be walked — and what can be set down is only the difference between those who came out the other side carrying a stronger faith than they brought in and those who got stuck somewhere in the middle, a difference that is not a formula but something closer to the shared habits of good travelers, who arrive by different routes, at different paces, with different temperaments, and yet hold a few disciplines in common. The disciplines are what can be taught.

READ THE SOURCES, AND STAY WITH WHAT HURTS: READING SCRIPTURE FOR YOURSELF

The first discipline is to stop reading about the

No seminary degree is required for this, only a Bible, a few introductory books by careful scholars on either side of the questions that matter, and the humility to stay with the text rather than skim it — and most who deconstruct discover, after three months of actual reading, that the critics and the defenders they had trusted were both working from sloppy, secondhand versions of the sources, when the primary texts themselves turn out to be more interesting, more complicated, and more persuasive than any of the summaries handed down to them.

The second discipline follows directly from the first: refuse to look away from the parts of the Bible that are difficult. When a passage unsettles, the temptation runs in two directions at once — to dismiss it as proof that the whole book is broken, or to explain it away until it stops bothering anyone — and both are evasions. The right move is to stay in front of the passage: to read it slowly, to read it alongside commentators who disagree with each other, to ask what it would have meant to its first readers and what it still means now, and to let the difficulty be difficult.

The binding of Isaac, the conquest narratives, the

FIND THE SAINTS WHO WRESTLED: THE PSALMS OF LAMENT, AUGUSTINE, AND THE DOUBTERS BEFORE YOU

The third discipline is to find out who in the history of the church asked these questions first, and then to read them — which may be the most consoling discovery available to anyone in the middle of deconstruction, because whatever the trial happens to be, someone has already been through it, written about it, come out the other side with faith intact, and left a map behind.

For the grieving and the angry there are the Psalms, a full curriculum in holy complaint, more than a third of them laments; and Psalm 88, the darkest poem in the whole book, ends in unresolved darkness because God placed that psalm in the songbook on purpose. Grief is in the Bible. Anger at God is in the Bible. It is not a sign of having left the faith — it is a sign of having finally entered it.

For doubt there is Augustine's Confessions, and Dostoevsky, and the Cloud of Unknowing; there is Julian of Norwich, who watched a plague kill a third of her

O Lord, how long shall I cry for help, and you will not hear?

— HABAKKUK 1:2

None of these were weaklings; they were saints, and some of them died for the faith after the wrestling was done. To stand in that company is to be carried for a little while — and the favor gets returned someday, for someone the wrestler will never meet.

REFUSE THE BINARY: WHY FAITH DOES NOT REQUIRE CERTAINTY

The fourth discipline is to refuse the false choice that the apologetics industry and the deconstruction industry both insist upon: the one says that if every doubt cannot be resolved the faith is broken, and the other says that if every doubt cannot be resolved the faith is a lie, and both are wrong, because the faith is not a deductive proof. It is a relationship with a person who rose from the dead, held within a community, tested against the witness of the Scriptures and the history of the tradition — and a relationship can carry unresolved questions, because a living faith always has them.

Thomas was not rebuked; he was offered wounds to touch. The Jesus of the Gospels is not more fragile than the one Thomas met, which means the unresolved questions may remain unresolved as long as they need to — what matters is staying in motion toward the truth and continuing to examine it.

STAY IN A LOCAL BODY: WHY A FEED CANNOT REPLACE A CHURCH

The fifth discipline is the hardest for many, and it is to stay embedded in an actual church through the whole of it — not necessarily the church where the wounding happened, since that may not be possible, but a church, a small group, a community of believers who know a name and will pray for the one who cannot pray that week.

The deconstruction pipeline on social media is a solitary practice engineered to keep its subjects isolated, an algorithm that feeds more content, more angry voices, more confirmation, until the whole thing begins to feel like community when it is only a feed — and a feed cannot hold

Churches that can bear hard questions do exist, though not always obviously, and often they are smaller than the one that did the harm, less polished, led by pastors who are tired rather than triumphant — so sit in the back a while, tell one person the story, and if they can hold it, stay, and if they cannot, try somewhere else. Do not abandon the body because the body disappointed, because the body is the means of grace in the New Testament, the way Christ keeps showing up; without it comes the attempt to manufacture what only the body can give, and the manufacture fails.

PRACTICE WHAT YOU ARE NOT SURE OF: HOW PRAYER AND PRACTICE SHAPE BELIEF

The sixth discipline is the strangest and the most reliable: keep praying, keep reading, keep showing up, even when belief is in doubt — especially then. The old monastic tradition called this a discipline of the body that eventually catches up with the heart, the practice coming before the feeling of the practice and, over time, shaping the self performing it. An atheist who began kneeling in prayer out of intellectual curiosity would not, a year later, be the same atheist. That is not manipulation. That is how bodies work.



– ATTRIBUTED TO C. S. LEWIS

Lewis held that prayer is not a mechanism for changing God but a means of becoming the kind of person for whom certain things are possible, and the same holds for every Christian practice — communion, confession, singing, reading the Scriptures aloud, giving, serving, sabbath — none of which require certainty, all of which form a self that becomes, over time, more able to see what is actually there. Belief is not the price of admission to the practices. The practices are how belief is built, and usually in that order.

LET THE REBUILD DIFFER FROM THE ORIGINAL: WHAT FAITH LOOKS LIKE AFTER DECONSTRUCTION

The seventh discipline is a kind of permission: faith after deconstruction will not look the same as faith before, and that is not a tragedy but the point. A renovated house is not the house it used to be; it is a better house on the same foundation, the load-bearing walls exposed and repaired — and some of what was believed before was never load-bearing at all, so its absence will not be missed, while some of it will return reshaped, deeper, held more carefully because the cost of getting there is now known.

The outcome may be more theologically settled on some questions and less politically committed on others, more attached to the local church and less to the celebrity culture of the platform, more confident about the essentials and less about the accretions — but whatever it turns out to be, it will belong to the one who wrestled for it. Not a parent's faith. Not a youth pastor's. Not a favorite

It is not quick. Anyone who claims to have come out the other side in six months is either lying or still going, because a real renovation takes years, sometimes a decade, and there is no falling behind, since there is no schedule.

It is not painless. There will be grief and anger, nights of believing none of it and mornings when the grief lands in a grocery aisle and forces a retreat to the parking lot — the ordinary shape of loss and reformation happening at once.

It is not without witnesses.



Therefore, since we are surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses, let us run with endurance the race that is set before us.

— HEBREWS 12:1

They went before, and they are not gone. The cloud cannot be seen, but it can be felt — in the songs that still cannot be sung without crying, in the old prayers that have never been left behind, in the Sunday set aside for staying home that ends with weeping in the kitchen. The path through is real; it will cost more than anyone wants to pay and give more than anyone expected. What remains is the next step, and the witnesses watching it taken.

CHAPTER EIGHT

What the Church Owes the Deconstructors

*How the Church Should Respond to
Deconstruction — Truth-Telling, a Theology of
Suffering, Costly Repentance, and the Long Game
of Welcome*

This chapter is for the pastors, the parents, the elders, the small-group leaders, the church members who have watched someone they love walk away and have not known what to do — and it is the hardest chapter in the book, because the one indicted most severely is the church itself, and the church includes the people writing and reading these words. This word is not handed down from a platform. It is handed across a table.

**THE DEBTS WE HAVE NOT PAID: TRUTH-
TELLING, HONEST QUESTIONS, AND A
THEOLOGY OF SUFFERING**

This means pastors saying, from the pulpit — not on social media, not in a carefully worded statement, but on a Sunday morning — that we have defended things that should never have been defended, that we have made the gospel sound like a tribal banner, that we have let celebrity culture into our movement and then protected the celebrities at the cost of their victims, that we have confused the kingdom of God with a political project, and that we have preached purity in ways that crushed the very people we were charged to guard. Specific sins named specifically, without the passive voice and without the softening adjectives. The deconstructors are watching to see whether we can do this, and almost none of them expect us to — yet the pastor who does it will find that some of the deconstructors in his extended family appear in the back pew on a Sunday he did not expect, while some will not, and some will need more time, and all of them will know, for the first time in years, that the truth is speakable in this building.

We owe them honest engagement with the questions

We owe them a theology of suffering, because the American church has been preaching, in many of its expressions, a functional theology of breakthrough that falls apart the first time life hits a wall, and we have to replace it with the New Testament's actual theology of suffering — the one in which Paul wrote half the New Testament from prison, Peter told his readers to count it a privilege to share in Christ's sufferings, and James opened his letter with instructions about trials. Jesus told his disciples plainly:

 *In the world you will have tribulation.*

— JOHN 16:33

The book of Job sits in the middle of the Bible for a reason, and its answer is not why the suffering came but who God is in the middle of it — which makes it not optional material but the spine of the tradition, so that a church that has misplaced it has to recover it. The people we have been losing hit walls we told them would never come; we have to tell them the truth about walls, and about

We owe them the whole Bible, not only the parts that support our tribe's current position, and that means we preach through books, we sit inside a text, and we let Scripture ask us hard questions rather than only supply answers to the questions we were already asking — we stop using verses like credentials and start reading the Bible like the strange, difficult, living document it is. We let Isaiah indict our economics, the prophets indict our politics, the Sermon on the Mount indict our social-media habits, and First John ask whether we actually love one another. A church whose congregants have never once heard a pastor preach against their own tribe's favorite political instincts is a church that has not shown them what the authority of Scripture looks like in practice; they have seen tribal signaling dressed up as preaching, and they can tell the difference. Show them preaching. The people leaving have read the Gospels, and they can tell when Jesus is missing from the sermon.

SPACE TO GRIEVE OUT LOUD: MAKING THE CHURCH SAFE FOR REAL LAMENT

We owe them space to grieve out loud — which means we have to make the church a place where a woman can speak of her miscarriages and no one tells her God has a plan, where a young man can say he has cancer and no one tells him God will not give him more than he can handle, where someone walks in one Sunday with red eyes and the person in the next seat can say I see you and ask nothing further, where the prayer requests in the bulletin include my marriage is dying, or my child has stopped speaking to me, or I am afraid I am losing my faith. Real

*The moment the church becomes a
performance space, we lose the
grieving. The moment we lose the
grieving, we lose the honest.*

The deconstructors left in part because the performance was too loud, so we have to turn it off and start being people again — and this is slow work that starts with the pastor, because if the pastor is performing, everyone is performing, and if the pastor is a real person, the room will, very slowly, give itself permission to be real too.

WELCOME WITHOUT COMPROMISE: HOLDING GRACE AND TRUTH AT ONCE

We owe them a posture of welcome without compromise, and this is the balance the American church has had the hardest time holding — some churches have welcomed so expansively that they no longer stand for anything, while others have drawn lines so aggressively that welcome has disappeared. Jesus held both at once: he invited Matthew to dinner without pretending Matthew's extortion was fine, he forgave the woman at the well without pretending she had been well, and he received tax collectors and prostitutes and sinners while calling them,

The deconstructors are not, mostly, asking for the ethic to be removed; they are asking for the welcome to be real — to come with their questions, their scars, and their partial faith, and to be received as human beings on a path rather than as problems to be solved. A church that can hold that posture will see some of them return. A church that cannot will not.

REPENTANCE, VISIBLE AND COSTLY: WHY PASTORS MUST SHOW THE CRACKS

We owe them honesty about ourselves, and our own repentance, visible and costly — because the deconstructor is tired of pastors who are too polished and wants to see the cracks, to know what the pastor has doubted, what he has repented of, and what he still has not figured out. This is not a call for performative vulnerability, which is only the new polish; it is a call for the real thing, which is far harder, because it means risking one's authority and discovering that, paradoxically, authority is gained by risking it.

Consider the pastor who stood up one Sunday and said: I do not know why my daughter is not well, I have prayed every prayer I know, nothing has helped, and I am going to preach the text now, because the text is true whether my daughter is well or not — but I wanted you to know where I am. That sermon is still mentioned in that congregation ten years later, not for the exegesis but for the honesty, because the deconstructors in that church heard something they had not heard from a pulpit in a long time. They heard a man who was not performing.

THE LONG GAME: STAYING A CHURCH PEOPLE CAN COME BACK TO

We owe them the long game, because a deconstructor who walks away today may come back in three years, or seven, or seventeen, and the church's task is to remain the same church they could come back to — which means we stay known, we do not go silent when they leave, we send the Christmas card, we ask after them when we see their parents, and we keep the door open without making the door a trap. We do not push. We do not guilt. Some will come home and some will not, and the faithfulness is in the staying, not in the return rate.

The American church, taken as a whole, has not yet done what it would take to earn the return of the people it has lost: we have not repented publicly at the scale our failures demand, we have not reformed our pulpits on the matters most in question, and we have not rebuilt the trust

If you are a pastor who recognizes yourself and your church in what has been named here, the response is not despair but to begin — to begin tomorrow, to begin the sermon you have been afraid to preach, to begin the repentance you have been avoiding, to begin the conversation with the person whose number is still in your phone, whose face you still see in the third pew on Sundays that have not come in a long time. Begin. The church has always reformed itself one faithful beginning at a time, and ours will too — or we will not reform, and we will disappear, and a different church will be raised up in our place, and that will also be the mercy of God.

A WORD TO THE ONE WHO STAYED UNTIL THE END

To the deconstructor who has made it to the end of this book: no one here knows what you are going to decide, and no one is trying to manipulate you into a decision — the aim is only to tell you the truth that has been found, so that whatever you decide, you decide with the truth available to you. The church you left may not be a church worth returning to. Jesus is still worth returning to. The church at her best — and she is not always at her best — is the body that carries him forward in the world; find her, or let her find you, because she is not always who she has seemed to be. Underneath the accretions, she is the people of God,

CHAPTER NINE

The Sociology of Loss

*Why This Generation Is Leaving Christianity –
Politics, the Internet, Trauma, Abuse, and the
Collapse of Trust in Institutions*

Every generation has its doubters, and every era has produced people who set down the faith they were handed, so the bare fact of departure proves nothing. What the American church is watching now is different in scale and in character, and the difference is the whole point. The question is not whether people leave; they always have. The question is why this generation, raised in this version of American Christianity, is leaving at rates with no precedent in the modern history of the church — and answering that honestly means setting down the explanation most pastors reach for first, the one that says the culture got worse and faithfulness got harder, and picking up a harder set of tools instead.

That preferred explanation is not entirely wrong, and it would be foolish to pretend otherwise. The culture has shifted, secularism has advanced, and the plausibility structures that once made belief in God seem obvious have

But the culture-is-worse account is incomplete, and often self-serving — it lets the church off the hook by treating the loss as external weather rather than internal rot. The generational data does not support the claim that American secularism alone accounts for the scale of the departure: secularism advanced in Europe for a century, and the American church watched European decline for decades while congratulating itself on being different. Something else happened here, in the last forty years, that broke the trust. The culture cannot explain it. Only the church can.

*The institution reads the exit as
apostasy. The young person reads it as
integrity.*

The deconstruction wave is best understood as a delayed reckoning with specific choices the American church made in the last generation, and the generational

THE FAITH THAT CAME WRAPPED IN A FLAG: WHEN EVANGELICALISM BECAME A POLITICAL TRIBE

Consider what shaped this generation. They are the first Americans who grew up entirely inside a culture war the church was understood to be fighting, and that timing matters more than any single doctrine they were taught. Their parents had come of age in a church that was still, in some ways, a cultural default — a place where politics was present but not primary — but by the 2010s the political valence of American evangelicalism was no longer implicit; it was the thing itself. You could not attend a large evangelical church in those years without meeting political signaling as a core feature of the experience: the worship service wrapped itself in a flag, the sermons named the cultural enemies, and the bookstore carried the campaign-season paperbacks. The faith these young people received was therefore not a faith they could ever separate from the politics, and by the time they were old enough to think about it, they could not imagine evangelical Christianity as anything but a political tribe that happened to have a god.

That was a choice the church made, and it did not have to make it. There were voices at the time warning against it, and those voices were marginalized; the choice was made anyway, because political alignment felt like power, and power felt like the way to protect the things the church

A generation that senses its elders did not mean what they said does not leave the faith first; it leaves the institution. It says, in effect, I will keep Jesus but I will not keep this church, because this church has shown me that its public commitments are negotiable and its private commitment is to power. The institution reads the exit as apostasy. The young person reads it as integrity — and the tragedy is that the young person is more often right than wrong, while the institution lacks the self-knowledge to hear it.

This is why so many deconstruction stories share a shape: they do not begin with a doctrinal objection but with a moral revulsion, with something that happened in the home church or in the national news that exposed the gap between what the church said and what the church did. The young person raised the gap, usually first to a parent, and was shut down; raised it to a pastor, and was told they were being influenced by the world; raised it in Bible study, and watched the adults rally to defend whatever had exposed the gap. What the young person

RAISED BY THE INTERNET: THE GENERATION THAT CAN SMELL A COVER-UP

A second factor is more diffuse and equally important: this is the first generation that grew up with the internet, which means they did not only hear the church's version of the church's story but heard every other version, from every other source, at a speed and density no previous generation had to process. When a denomination mishandled an abuse case, the young person in youth group did not wait for the national media; they heard it on a podcast a week after it broke. When a celebrity pastor fell, they watched the fall in real time, then watched the statements from the surrounding institutions, then watched those statements get revised as new facts surfaced, then measured the distance between the first statement and the final fact. They developed, as a cohort, a forensic sense for institutional evasion — they can smell a non-apology at a distance, and they can tell when a press release was written by a lawyer. The medium trained them to notice institutional dishonesty, and when they turn that trained attention on the church, they find plenty.

This is not a failure on their part; it is a feature of the world they were given. Any church strategy that assumes the young person can be persuaded to trust the institution

A GENERATION THAT TAKES PAIN SERIOUSLY: FAITH, TRAUMA, AND THE THERAPIST WHO LISTENED

A third factor is that this generation has a different relationship to suffering than the generations before it, and that relationship deserves to be taken seriously before it is dismissed. They have been told, from kindergarten forward, that their feelings matter, that pain is real, that trauma is a legitimate category of experience, and that healing is a legitimate goal — and some of this is cultural excess, therapeutic language escaping the clinical setting where it belongs, while some of it is a genuine correction against the emotional repression that shaped earlier generations. The correction has limits, and it can slide into a self-absorbed fragility that treats every discomfort as trauma. But it is not nothing, and the church that wants to minister to this generation has to meet it inside its emotional vocabulary, not outside it.

The problem is that much of American evangelical preaching runs on an implicit anthropology that treats

THE COST OF INSTITUTIONAL SILENCE: WATCHING THE ABUSE CRISES UNFOLD

A fourth factor is that this generation has watched, more closely than any before it, the cost of institutional silence on specific moral questions. They watched the Catholic abuse crisis, they watched the Southern Baptist abuse crisis, and they watched the coverups in large nondenominational networks; they watched how long the institutions took to admit what everyone already knew, and how those institutions treated survivors during the admission. They have absorbed, at the level of cellular memory, a truth their parents could more easily ignore: that institutional self-protection is the default instinct of every institution, the church included, and that the church's claim to moral authority is only as strong as its willingness to act against its own interest when the stakes require it. They have watched the church mostly fail that test, and they are not willing to pretend otherwise.

A pastor who likes this sort of answer can complain

THE COLLAPSE OF DEFERENCE: WHY THE CHURCH NO LONGER GETS A PASS ON TRUST

A fifth factor is more subtle: this generation has a different relationship to authority than any before it, and that relationship was shaped not primarily by the academy or by progressive politics, as the cultural-decline narrative claims, but by the internet and by the experience of watching every traditional authority expose itself in real time. They watched the media misrepresent Iraq, they watched the financial institutions misrepresent the housing bubble, they watched the medical institutions fumble the pandemic, and they watched the political institutions abandon norms those same institutions had spent decades calling sacred. By the time they were old enough to be asked to trust the church, they had already been trained to assume that every institution misleads as a matter of course, and that claims of moral authority are mostly cover for the real agenda.

THE WORK THAT REMAINS: WHAT KEEPS THIS GENERATION, AND WHAT LOSES IT

What does this mean for the pastor who takes the generational character of the exit seriously? A few things, and the first is to take the institutional critique on its own terms rather than reframing it as a spiritual problem. The young person who says evangelicalism has been corrupted by politics is making a claim that can be engaged — so engage it, by showing where the church has not been corrupted, where the preaching pushed back against political captivity, where the moral witness has been consistent rather than tribal. If those things cannot be shown, the young person has a point, and there is work to do. The first step is not to defend the institution; the first step is to be an institution worth defending.

Second, accept the internet reality, because the competition is no longer the Gospel of Thomas but a forty-minute, well-sourced podcast on the denomination's recent abuse coverup, and the young person will hear it whether you like it or not. That cannot be prevented; what

Third, develop a pastoral theology of emotional experience that does not treat feelings as a category to be corrected with doctrine, because feelings are data — not the final word, but data. A person in real grief needs Scripture and also needs to be allowed to grieve; a person with real anxiety needs the Psalms and also needs to be told the anxiety is not a sin; a person who has endured real trauma needs the cross and also needs to be told that what happened was not God's will, that God grieves with them, and that the way through is longer than a verse. The church that cannot say those things will lose the young person in the first serious crisis of adult life. The church that can say them keeps the chance to hold on.

Fourth, understand that the demand for moral consistency is not going away, and do not resent it. A generation that grew up watching institutions betray their own stated values will not extend credit to any institution, this one included, on the strength of a claim; credit is earned, repeatedly, by action. To keep the young person, a pastor and a church have to match practice to preaching and answer the inevitable mismatch with honest confession rather than spin. This is not a lowering of the bar. It is a return to the bar the church set and then mostly abandoned.

The sociology of the loss is not destiny, and the generational factors are not deterministic; individual pastors and individual congregations can still make a difference, but the difference will be made only by leaders who understand what the young person is actually experiencing — which is not a failure of cultural faithfulness in a hostile environment, but a reckoning with specific choices the American church made over the last forty years, now that the young person has had time to assess them. Louder preaching will not stop it. Harder catechism will not stop it. It will be stopped, where it is stopped at all, by churches that repent of what was wrong, keep what was right, and build something a young person can tell the truth inside of.



Whoever conceals his transgressions will not prosper, but he who confesses and forsakes them will obtain mercy.

— PROVERBS 28:13

That is the work. It is slower than a program and harder than a conference, and it is the only thing that will hold.

CHAPTER TEN

Science, Creation, and the False Choice

*Faith and Science Without the False Choice —
Genesis, Young-Earth Creationism, Evolution,
and Whether a Christian Has to Pick*

Consider the young man raised in a household where evolution was a lie, the universe was six thousand years old, and the geological record was the residue of Noah's flood — and consider him now, at thirty, two semesters of college biology and a few books on cosmology read for pleasure behind him, having concluded that the scientific account of the natural world is, on its own terms, compelling. He did not set out to reject his childhood faith; he set out to understand the world, and the rejection followed only because the adults in his life, and the books they handed him, had told him that to accept the scientific account was to reject the Bible. He accepted the account, assumed the rejection was required, and walked. No one had given him the resources to think otherwise.

This story is not rare — it is one of the most common

This chapter will say things that are uncomfortable for pastors and congregations that have built their identity on a young-earth, anti-evolutionary posture, but the point is not to ask anyone to abandon convictions — it is that the posture be held with an honesty that has too often been missing. Hold the young-earth position, if you must, because you have weighed the arguments on both sides and concluded it has the better of them; do not hold it because you have been told that to hold otherwise is to deny the faith. That claim is historically false, theologically shallow, and pastorally catastrophic, and it is responsible, directly, for the loss of a significant share of the young people who have left the evangelical church over the last

WHAT THE TEXT IS FOR: READING GENESIS 1 AND 2 AS ANCIENT THEOLOGY

The opening chapters of Genesis are extraordinary pieces of ancient literature, functioning as theological polemic against the surrounding creation myths of the ancient Near East, and they make their argument by borrowing the structural features of those myths while subverting their content. Where the other accounts featured gods in conflict, humans made from the blood of defeated deities to serve as slaves, and a cosmos that was precarious and arbitrary, Genesis 1 and 2 feature one God who speaks the world into being, humans made in the divine image with royal dignity, and a cosmos that is ordered and good. This is the theological work the text is doing: it tells the Israelites what kind of world they live in, what kind of God made it, and what kind of creatures they are inside it. This is what the text is for.

What the text is not for is what a modern scientific textbook is for — it is not providing a chronology of the geological record, it is not specifying the mechanisms by which species arose, and it is not offering an astronomical account of stellar formation, because the questions a scientist asks are not the questions the text was written to answer. To force the text to answer them, and then to grade the answer against the findings of modern science, is to misuse the text in a way its own authors would not recognize. The early church fathers knew this; they read

The young-earth position, in anything like its contemporary form, is a product of the early twentieth century — it was not the majority view of the Christian tradition before 1920. It gained prominence in American fundamentalism through the work of George McCready Price, a Seventh-day Adventist, and it was carried to the broader evangelical world by Henry Morris and John Whitcomb in 1961 with the publication of *The Genesis Flood*, a book that, more than any other, shaped the creationist movement of the late twentieth century and presented its conclusions as though they were the historic Christian position. They were not. They were a recent interpretive move, built on questionable geology, pitched to a population that lacked the tools to weigh the geological claims on their merits.

None of this means the young-earth position is without serious defenders today, or that every argument for it is bad; some of its defenders are careful and honest. But the framing handed down to most American evangelical young people is neither, because that framing holds that to accept an old earth is to compromise biblical authority, that to accept common descent is to deny the gospel, and that any Christian who accepts the mainstream scientific account has been captured by the world — and that framing is false at every level. The history of Christian interpretation does not support it, the theology of Scripture does not require it, and its pastoral fruit is, as we are watching in real time, catastrophic.

Put it more directly: if the cost of holding the young-earth line has been that a significant portion of the rising generation has concluded that Christianity itself is intellectually indefensible, then the line has been too expensive. The church has survived every previous scientific revolution, including the Copernican one — which was far more threatening to its worldview than anything on offer today — and it survived because, every time, Christian thinkers did the hard work of showing that the faith could hold the new knowledge without losing its core. The church that refuses that work now is not defending the gospel. It is abandoning the young people the gospel exists to save.

THE WORD DOING TOO MUCH WORK: WHAT EVOLUTION ACTUALLY CLAIMS

A word about evolution, because the term is doing so much work in so many Christian conversations that it has nearly lost its meaning: in mainstream biology, evolution refers to the change in heritable traits in a population across generations, through mechanisms that include natural selection, genetic drift, and mutation, and it is among the best-supported theories in the history of science, confirmed by converging evidence from paleontology, comparative anatomy, molecular biology,

What is sometimes controversial is the philosophical extrapolation — the claim that evolution demonstrates the nonexistence of God, or that it reduces human beings to material machines with no spiritual reality — and these are philosophical claims, not scientific ones, which Christians can rightly resist. But the scientific core, that life developed over deep time through natural processes, is not in scientific dispute, and it is not in conflict with anything the Bible actually teaches.

A Christian can hold that God is the creator, that human beings bear the divine image, that the soul is real and non-reducible, that sin is catastrophic and in need of redemption, and that Jesus is the incarnate Son of God who died and rose again, while also accepting that the universe is roughly 13.8 billion years old, that the earth is 4.5 billion years old, that life developed through evolutionary processes, and that humans share common ancestors with other primates — a synthesis Christians have held for over a century, one that many of the most influential theologians of the twentieth century, C. S. Lewis among them, held in some form. The synthesis requires abandoning no core Christian conviction; it requires only abandoning the assumption that Genesis 1 and 2 were written to function as a scientific account. That assumption is not biblical. It is cultural.

ONE THING TO STOP DOING: WHY SCIENCE IS NOT THE ENEMY OF THE BIBLE

The pastor not ready to adopt the synthesis is not being

Augustine, in his commentary on Genesis, warned explicitly against Christians making definitive interpretive claims about Scripture in areas where natural philosophy was still being worked out, because he saw that such overconfidence would turn outsiders away from the faith over nothing — and he was right in the fourth century just as he is right now, because many of the young people lost in recent years have lost their faith over exactly the thing Augustine warned against. The warning has been available for sixteen hundred years. The church that did not listen is now counting the cost.

Turn, briefly, to the positive case, because a Christianity that can receive the findings of modern science is not a diminished Christianity but, in some ways, a richer one: the universe is older, larger, and stranger than the young-earth framework allowed, and read against the backdrop of cosmology, the creation story is not less awe-inspiring but more — billions of years of stars forming and dying to forge the heavy elements that make up a human body, galaxies colliding across timescales that dwarf the whole human story, life developing on one small planet through mechanisms whose elegance is its own argument for design. The doctrine of creation, as it turns out, was never small enough to fit inside six literal days;

The young person told all his life that to follow the evidence is to leave the faith hears that frame as an ultimatum, and many choose the evidence, because the evidence is compelling — which is why the gift a faithful pastor can give is the removal of the ultimatum: that the evidence is not the enemy, that the God of the Bible is also the God of the physical universe, that the scientific method used honestly is a gift whose findings do not threaten the faith but enrich it, and that the person of Jesus Christ is not remotely contingent on the resolution of evolutionary questions.

This is not a compromise. It is the historic Christian confidence — the faith of Augustine, of Aquinas, of C. S. Lewis, and what the tradition has looked like, most of the time, when it was operating at its best. The American evangelical movement of the last century narrowed the tradition to an interpretive position the tradition never uniformly held, then presented that narrow position as the only faithful one, and that was a mistake, a costly one. It is not too late to stop making it.

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE IN A LOCAL CHURCH: TEACHING FAITH AND SCIENCE HONESTLY

Begin in the pulpit: preach through Genesis 1 and 2 as the ancient theological literature they are, and let the text do what it was written to do. Show the congregation the polemical work the text performs against the surrounding

When the scientific questions do come, address them with honesty about what the text claims and does not claim, and with humility about the interpretive options the tradition has held: present young-earth creationism as one option, with its defenders and its difficulties; present old-earth creationism; present evolutionary creationism; and do not pretend one of them is the only faithful position. Let the congregation see that thoughtful Christians have held various views, and that the faith does not hang on the resolution.

Build, in the congregation, a curiosity about the natural world that reflects the goodness of creation — take the people outside, show them the telescopes, let them see that the world God made is an endless source of wonder, and that Christians have no reason to fear any of it. A congregation that loves the world God made will be harder to shake when the world turns up something unexpected.

When young people arrive with questions that grew out of their science classes, do not shut them down: do not call their college biology professor a Marxist ideologue, do not hand them a DVD from 1998 that purports to debunk carbon dating, but listen to the question, take it seriously, and say — I do not know everything about this; let me look into it, and get back to you. That sentence, from a pastor, is worth more than a thousand confident wrong answers.

Find the books and the resources, because they exist

THE BATTLE THAT WAS NEVER REQUIRED: THE FALSE CHOICE BETWEEN THE BIBLE AND SCIENCE

The old battle, between a flat-footed biblical literalism and mainstream science, was a battle the church was always going to lose, because it was fought on terms the church never needed to accept: the choice was never between the Bible and science but between a recent American evangelical reading of Genesis and the findings of the natural sciences. The reading can be corrected. The sciences will not be rolled back.

A faith that has defined itself by the reading is a faith hemorrhaging the generation that followed the sciences, while a faith that defines itself by the person of Jesus Christ can hold the sciences, ask larger questions than the sciences ask, and offer answers the sciences cannot give. That faith is still available, and the young person who left over the false choice is still reachable — if the church will give him the faith it should have given him in the first



*If what we think the Bible teaches conflicts with
what we can demonstrate about the world, let us
reexamine our reading; the God who wrote the one
also authored the other.*

— AFTER AUGUSTINE, DE GENESI AD LITTERAM

The warning is sixteen centuries old, and the history of the interpretive options is a matter of public record, which means the next generation can be told the truth and trusted to think, with the confidence that the God who made them, mind and all, will meet them in the thinking. That is the least the church can do for the generation in front of it, and it is more than most of the church was willing to do for the last one. The difference can begin in a single congregation, this Sunday, with one honest sentence from the pulpit.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Problem of Hell Revisited

*Rethinking Hell – Eternal Conscious Torment,
Annihilationism, and Universalism, and What
the Bible Actually Teaches About Sheol, Hades,
and Gehenna*

For many who deconstruct, hell is the doctrine that finally pushes them over the edge — not the first thing they doubt, but the last thing they can hold. They can live with the tension between providence and suffering; they can live with the stranger corners of the Old Testament; they can even live with the church's political captivity by holding their nose and finding a different congregation. What they cannot live with is a doctrine of eternal conscious torment preached as the plain reading of Scripture and presented as though any Christian who held otherwise had simply denied the faith. The doctrine, as they received it, made God a moral monster, and the monster did not match the Jesus of the Gospels. The mismatch became unsupportable, and faith broke.

THE WORD THAT DOES TOO MUCH: SHEOL, HADES, GEHENNA, AND WHAT HELL TRANSLATES

Start with the vocabulary, because the trouble begins there. The English word hell renders several different words from the biblical languages, and those words do not all mean the same thing. The Hebrew Sheol referred, in most Old Testament usage, to the grave or the underworld — a shadowy place where the dead, righteous and wicked alike, were understood to go — and it was not primarily a place of torment. The Greek Hades, used in the Septuagint to translate Sheol and then again in the New Testament, carries a similar range. Gehenna, the word on Jesus' lips in

A young person who meets these facts for the first time, often in a college religion course or on a podcast rather than in church, is going to be disoriented, because they were told the Bible had a clear doctrine of hell and now they learn that the English word is doing enormous interpretive work the underlying languages do not do in the same way. The disorientation can tip into cynicism; they begin to wonder what else was presented as plain biblical teaching when it was actually interpretive tradition wearing the costume of certainty. And the cynicism is not entirely unwarranted. The plain-reading claim, pressed onto complex texts that will not bear the weight, has done more damage to young faith than almost any other habit of the evangelical pulpit.

WHAT JESUS ACTUALLY SAID ABOUT HELL, AND WHAT ISAIAH MEANT

Take the teaching of Jesus directly, since that is where the argument has to be won or lost. He spoke about judgment a great deal, and the language was vivid and serious — weeping and gnashing of teeth, fire that is not quenched, the worm that does not die — terrifying images that any honest reading of the Gospels must reckon with,

*And they shall go out and look on the dead bodies of
the men who have rebelled against me. For their
worm shall not die, their fire shall not be quenched,
and they shall be an abhorrence to all flesh.*

— ISAIAH 66:24

The referent is corpses, not living beings in conscious torment — and the distinction is everything. The fire burns and the worm consumes because there is nothing left to burn or consume, not because the burning is an ongoing punishment inflicted on an ongoing victim. This is not a fringe reading smuggled in to soften the doctrine; it is what the text Jesus was quoting actually says, in the plainest sense of plain.

Does that settle what Jesus meant? No — and the chapter does not pretend it does. But it does mean the confident claim, made from a thousand pulpits, that Jesus clearly taught eternal conscious torment is overstated. What he demonstrably did was take up images whose original referent was the destruction of the wicked and apply them to the final judgment; whether he intended those images to carry the old referent forward, which is destruction, or to transform them into something genuinely new, which is endless torment, is precisely the matter on which careful Christians have disagreed, and disagreed in good faith, for as long as the question has

THREE POSITIONS, ALL OF THEM ORTHODOX: ETERNAL TORMENT, ANNIHILATIONISM, AND UNIVERSALISM

Three positions have a long history in the church and have been held by Christians who were, by any reasonable measure, serious and orthodox. The first is eternal conscious torment, the default most American evangelicals received — the view that the wicked, at the final judgment, are consigned to a state of conscious suffering that never ends; it draws support from certain readings of Matthew 25 and Revelation 20, and it was held by some of the early fathers. The second is conditional immortality, sometimes called annihilationism, which holds that the wicked are finally destroyed, so that their existence simply ends; it too was held by some early fathers, has been defended in the modern period by careful evangelicals like John Stott and Edward Fudge, and draws significant support from the language of destruction, perishing, and the second death that runs through the New Testament. The third is universal reconciliation, sometimes called Christian universalism, which holds that all, in the end, will be reconciled to God through Christ, though possibly after a period of judgment and purification; it was held by some of the greatest minds of the early church, among them Gregory of Nyssa, who was never declared a heretic for it, and it has had serious defenders since, including David Bentley Hart.

The argument here is not for one of these over the others — it is something the loud version cannot afford to admit. It is that the evangelical church has often presented

Why did no one tell them? Partly because the leaders they trusted did not know, since much American evangelical pastoral training, especially outside the seminaries that do careful work, never exposes pastors to the full range of the tradition on this question — and a pastor who has only ever encountered eternal conscious torment will assume it is the only option and preach it that way. Partly because the doctrine has been used, in too many settings, as an evangelistic lever, so that weakening the lever feels like weakening the evangelism itself. And partly because there is a cultural fear, understandable but not finally defensible, that opening the question will collapse into universalism and that universalism removes all urgency from the Christian life. None of these rises to the level of a good reason for silence about the actual range of Christian thought.

WHAT THE YOUNG PERSON WAS NEVER TOLD: THE HELL DOCTRINE THE TRADITION ITSELF QUESTIONED

Consider that even on the most traditional reading, hell is not something God does to people; it is, on most careful accounts, the state of the soul that has decisively and finally refused God. C. S. Lewis put it as memorably as

Consider, too, that the New Testament writers, when they speak of final judgment, lean heavily on the language of perishing, destruction, and death rather than on the language of endless suffering. The wages of sin is death, not eternal life in torment; the broad road leads to destruction; the chaff is burned up; the branch is cut off and burned. These images can be read in support of eternal conscious torment, but they can also, with equal textual legitimacy, be read in support of a view in which the unredeemed cease to be — which is exactly why conditional immortality has gained serious support among evangelical scholars over the last half century. It fits the language of the New Testament better than its critics admit, and it resolves the moral problem the young person is raising in a way the first position simply cannot.

*Many who rejected the doctrine of hell
were rejecting, without knowing it,
something the Christian tradition had*

Consider as well that the early church did not operate with one unified doctrine of hell, nor did it treat disagreement on this point as the line between orthodoxy and heresy. Gregory of Nyssa, whose trinitarian theology is foundational for orthodox Christianity, was a universalist; Origen, more controversially, held a version of the same view. The council that eventually censured certain universalist positions, the Fifth Ecumenical Council in 553, ratified a position that had already become dominant — but it did not eliminate the disagreement entirely, and it did not retroactively declare Gregory of Nyssa a heretic. The orthodox tradition has had far more room on this question than most contemporary evangelicals realize, and that room is still available to anyone willing to look for it.

Consider, finally, that the motivation behind the doctrine as it has been taught is frequently a desire to protect the seriousness of the gospel — and that motivation is not wrong. The gospel is serious, the stakes are real, and any account of judgment that dissolves the seriousness has given something up that cannot be given up. But a doctrine can guard that seriousness in more than one way: a doctrine that says the unrepentant perish and cease to be is serious, and a doctrine that says the unrepentant are finally reconciled after a refining judgment is serious. The seriousness does not require the specific picture of eternal torment to do its work. The gospel's urgency can survive a reconsideration of the doctrine's exact shape.

What, then, should a pastor do with all of this, given that most congregations are not ready for a fifteen-week seminary lecture on the history of eschatological thought?

First, stop preaching confident claims that exceed the evidence. A pastor who has held a version of eternal conscious torment for most of his ministry can continue to hold it while acknowledging that other serious Christians have held other positions — an acknowledgment that costs almost nothing from the pulpit and buys the young person a reason to stay. The alternative is an overclaiming that, once the young person discovers the truth about the history of Christian thought, will look like dishonesty and cost the preacher every ounce of credibility he had.

Second, when preaching on judgment, focus on the person of the Judge rather than the mechanics of the sentence — because the Judge is Jesus, and it is the Jesus of the Gospels who will judge. If that reframing creates problems, good; let them do their work. The cartoon Jesus who loves unconditionally in this life and then presides over eternal torture in the next is not the Jesus of the Gospels but a figure stitched together from half-read texts. The real Jesus is more complicated, and more trustworthy, than that.

Third, take the moral objection seriously rather than dismissing it as a sign the objector does not understand holiness. The young person who says, I cannot worship a God who would eternally torture people for a finite life of finite sin, is making an argument every serious Christian has had to wrestle with — one may disagree with the

Fourth, recover the tradition, and recover it firsthand. Read Gregory of Nyssa; read Origen; read Edward Fudge; read John Stott and watch an evangelical statesman defend conditional immortality in careful biblical terms; read David Bentley Hart's *That All Shall Be Saved*, not in order to agree with it but in order to see what a serious defense of universalism actually looks like rather than the caricature so often handed down; read even the Catholic tradition on purgatory, which is not the same as hell but illuminates how the tradition has thought about the posthumous condition. Let the tradition talk back. The reader will come out with more respect for the positions he still does not hold and more humility about the ones he does.

Fifth, preach the love of God with the same confidence the wrath of God has been preached, because the New Testament does not grant the right to separate these. The cross of Christ is simultaneously the revelation of wrath and of love, and any preaching that has emphasized one without the other has handed the congregation a half-gospel; if a decade of sermons has been heavy on judgment and light on love, the balance needs correcting — not because love is the only thing, but because love is the larger thing, the thing inside which the wrath exists rather than the thing standing alongside it. A God who does not love is not the Christian God. A God who only threatens is

THE FATHER IS WATCHING THE ROAD

To the young person who left over hell, the matter can be put directly and without flinching. The moral objection was not a sign of spiritual weakness; it was a sign of moral seriousness, and the doctrine as it was received deserved the objection it got. What was missing was not the objection but the rest of the conversation — and the rest of the conversation is available. No one has to accept the cartoon, and no one has to accept the version handed out in youth group by a leader who had never thought carefully about it. The texts can be read with fresh eyes, the tradition can be opened, and a person can come back to a faith that turns out to be bigger and stranger and more humane than the one they rejected.

The God of the Bible is not a torturer. The God of the Bible is the Father who runs to meet the prodigal while he is still a long way off, and the Judge of the final judgment is the same Judge who wept over Jerusalem:

O Jerusalem, Jerusalem, the city that kills the prophets and stones those who are sent to it! How often would I have gathered your children together as a hen gathers her brood under her wings, and you were not willing!

— MATTHEW 23:37

Whatever final judgment means, it means something consistent with that Judge, because that Judge is who he is — and the doctrine of hell, held honestly, has to be held inside that portrait rather than against it. Held outside it, it

CHAPTER TWELVE

Sexuality, the Body, and the Scriptural Imagination

*Sexuality, Purity Culture, and the Church –
Healing the Damage, the LGBTQ Question,
Transgender Questions, and a Biblical Theology
of the Body*

The Bible is more sexually conservative than most of the cultural options on offer today, and that is not the difficult claim; the difficult claim is the one the sexual ethics debate is rarely allowed to reach — that so many people leave the faith over the church's handling of sexuality when the underlying ethic, rightly understood, is not actually where the problem lies. The problem lies somewhere else. And the young person who left needs the church to be honest about where it lies, rather than honest about everything except the one thing they were waiting to hear named.

The package has to be disassembled before the ethic can be heard, and what follows is some of that disassembly — piece by piece, in the order the wounds were inflicted.

**WHAT PURITY CULTURE DID: THE
SHAME IT CAUSED AND WHY THE
CHURCH MUST APOLOGIZE**

Begin with purity culture, the most immediate source of pain for a significant portion of the deconstruction wave, because as it was practiced in American evangelicalism

The church has barely begun to reckon with what this did. The book that launched much of the movement, *I Kissed Dating Goodbye*, was eventually retracted by its own author — who now speaks publicly about the harm it caused and about his own subsequent departure from the faith — and that retraction should have been a moment of widespread institutional reflection. It was instead largely ignored by the very leaders who had promoted the book, because institutional self-protection is the default instinct of institutions, and acknowledging that the movement did harm would have cost too much. Meanwhile the young women who were told that their sexual history made them, in the analogy of the chewed gum or the used cup, permanently diminished, are now adult women: women with therapists, with marriages that required years of

A pastor serious about his congregation should apologize, from the pulpit, specifically, for what purity culture did — not in general terms but in particular ones. Name the teachings. Name the books. Name the conferences. Say plainly: we held these things up and they hurt people, here is what we got wrong, here is what the biblical sexual ethic actually is — demanding but not shaming — and here is what your relationship to your own past looks like under grace. The confession does not surrender the ethic; it returns the ethic to its actual proportions and strips away the ancillary claims that were never biblical in the first place. And the young women, and young men, who heard that specific apology might hear the whole gospel again for the first time in a decade.

THE QUESTION THAT EMPTIES PEWS: HOW THE CHURCH CARRIED ITS TEACHING ON HOMOSEXUALITY

Now the harder ground. Homosexuality has been, for a generation, the question over which more deconstruction has happened than any other, and it is worth asking why, because the biblical position is not unclear and the historic teaching of the church — across Catholic, Orthodox, and Protestant traditions — was unanimous until very recently. Nor are the reasons for the teaching arbitrary: they emerge from a biblical anthropology in which the complementarity of male and female, the image of God borne together by humanity, and the creational

Some of the responsibility lies with the surrounding culture, which has done significant work to make any traditional sexual ethic look like bigotry, and that point deserves its due. But most of the responsibility lies with the church itself. The church spent thirty years, from roughly 1980 to 2010, pouring enormous political energy into fighting public accommodations for gay people — arguing against the decriminalization of homosexuality, then against civil unions, then against marriage equality — while doing comparatively little to articulate a positive vision of singleness, chastity, friendship, and the moral life of the body. The priorities were lopsided, and the lopsidedness told the watching world, and the young people in the church's own pews, that the church cared more about the political containment of gay people than about the spiritual formation of anyone at all. The message was received.

It did not have to be this way. The church could have held the traditional teaching while refusing to make public-policy enforcement of that teaching its central political

To the young person who has deconstructed over this issue, several things must be said, and they are uncomfortable on both sides. First, the ethic itself, once the political baggage is stripped away, is not indefensible; it emerges from a biblical anthropology far richer than the caricatures handed down to defend it. Read Wesley Hill's *Washed and Waiting*. Read Eve Tushnet. Read Hill's own work on spiritual friendship. These are gay Christians who have held to the traditional teaching and articulated what it looks like from the inside, in ways the political combatants in both camps never managed. One may disagree with them at the end and still concede the thing that matters here: the position has defenders who have lived inside it with integrity. That position exists. It deserves a hearing.

Second, the way the question got litigated in public — as if the only options were full cultural affirmation and total exclusion — was never the only option, because the church has options inside its own life that the culture war did not allow to develop. The question is not whether the church will bless gay marriage. The question is whether the

Third, the way the church has treated gay people who are not Christians has done enormous damage to the gospel's public witness, because the young person who watched the gay uncle ostracized by Christian relatives, who watched the conservative church lobby against a gay friend's adoption rights, who heard the joke from the pulpit about the transgender person, has file cabinets full of evidence that the church is not, at least not for gay people, a place of grace. That evidence cannot be unseen, and the church that wants the young person to reconsider its position on the ethic has first to repent of the evidence — not spin it, not reframe it, but repent of it: the specific acknowledgment that the behavior was wrong, that the lobbying did not need to happen in the way it happened, that the joke was cruel, that the uncle should have been at the table. That repentance is the precondition for any further conversation, and most churches have not offered it.

BODIES, GIVENNESS, AND THE LIMITS OF THE CHURCH'S WISDOM: A PASTORAL POSTURE ON TRANSGENDER QUESTIONS

A serious pastoral posture on transgender questions will have a few features, and they hang together. It will insist that every person who experiences gender dysphoria is an image-bearer, not a symbol of cultural corruption or a battleground in a culture war; it will decline both the progressive position that medical intervention is always the right answer and the reactive position that gender dysphoria is always a delusion or a perversion; and it will take seriously the empirical data on outcomes, which is not as settled as either side pretends. It will be pastoral with individual people while teaching the

This posture is going to disappoint the loudest voices in the culture war, because the progressive voices will say it is not affirming enough and the reactive voices will say it is too accommodating, and the pastoral posture is not trying to win the culture war at all. It is trying to minister to the actual human beings who are suffering in front of it, while holding to the anthropology the faith has always taught, and doing so with the humility the complexity of the questions requires. That posture is harder than either political alternative. It is also the only one a serious pastor can hold for long.

AN ANTHROPOLOGY OF THE BODY: WHY THE BIBLE CALLS THE BODY GOOD, NOT THE ENEMY

The deeper issue beneath all of this, the one that feeds every individual question, is the church's anthropology of the body — because too much American evangelicalism, for too long, has operated with a functional anthropology more gnostic than Christian. It treated the body as a source of problems; it treated desire as contamination; it treated sexuality as, at best, a necessary evil sanctified by marriage. This anthropology is not biblical. The Bible

The sexual ethic of the Bible is demanding because it takes bodies seriously, not because it despises them. Chastity outside of marriage is a call to honor the body by refusing to use it, or to be used, for purposes the covenantal framework of sexual union was never made to bear; fidelity within marriage is a call to honor the body of the other as a gift rather than a possession. The ethic is exalted, not reductive. And when it has been preached reductively — as a set of shaming rules and a management regime for desire — it has been preached as something other than what the Bible actually offers.

The ethic they resented was, in many cases, the caricature of the ethic. The actual ethic, held inside a congregation that treats bodies well, is not an instrument of oppression. It is a path, hard but not impossible, toward a life that is more fully human.

THE THING ITSELF: THE ETHIC BENEATH THE CARICATURE

This is the congregation the young person has been looking for, and the pattern is plain enough: when they cannot find it, they leave; when they can find it, they stay, and sometimes they come back. The actual ethic, held inside a congregation that treats bodies well, is not what they resented — they resented the caricature, and the one who has heard only the caricature has not yet heard the thing itself. They can still be offered the thing itself.

The honesty this chapter has asked of the church can be tested in the pews, and where it has been tested the result is consistent. Where the goodness of the body, the

It can change everything for the one who deconstructed, too. The faith that frightened them with its rules is still there, but the version that frightened them was never the faith itself, because the faith is larger and the faith is kinder, and it takes the body more seriously, not less, than the cultural alternatives do. The faith asks more. The asking is part of the gift.



So God created man in his own image, in the image of God created he him; male and female created he them.

— GENESIS 1:27

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Spiritual Abuse Reckoning

*Spiritual Abuse in the Church — the Signs, the
Cover-Up Reflex, the Scandals That Broke a
Generation, and What Healing and
Accountability Require*

There is a kind of deconstruction that begins with neither doctrine nor cultural discomfort nor the ordinary friction of religious life — it begins with a specific person, in a specific position of spiritual authority, who used that authority to harm a specific victim. The harm may have been sexual, it may have been financial, or it may have been the slower and less visible harm of coercion, control, humiliation, and shame, perpetrated by the person and then covered over by the institution that should have stopped him. The victim walks out of that room changed, and the faith that was taught inside the room is now tangled with the memory of what happened inside it, so that pulling the two apart becomes the work of years.

A book on deconstruction that does not take this

WHAT THE WORD NAMES: DEFINING SPIRITUAL ABUSE AND ITS DISTINCTIVE HARM

Spiritual abuse, as the scholarly literature on the phenomenon uses the term, is the use of spiritual authority to control, coerce, manipulate, or harm another person — and while it includes the obvious forms, the pastoral sexual abuse and financial exploitation and physical violence by clergy or clergy-adjacent leaders, it also includes the quieter forms that never reach a courtroom and never make a headline.

Shaming people in front of the congregation for disagreeing with the pastor; weaponizing the membership covenant to punish dissent; using the language of submission to silence victims; deploying spiritual language to bypass ordinary ethical analysis — God has told me you need to do this, so the fact that it looks wrong is only evidence of your lack of faith; coaching spouses to

The harm is distinctive, and naming why matters. It is not merely the harm of the abuse itself, which would be enough to ruin a life; it is the harm of the abuse being inflicted in the name of God, in the language of God, by a representative of God — so that the victim cannot separate the abuser from the faith, because the spiritual imagination itself has been colonized. Prayer feels like manipulation, because manipulation was called prayer; Scripture feels like a weapon, because Scripture was used as a weapon; worship feels dangerous, because the abuser stood at the front and led the worship. The body carries the memory of what was done in churches, and the body recoils when it sees a church, hears a sermon, meets a verse — and this is not a failure of faith but the normal response of a human organism to trauma. To expect the victim to overcome it by force of will is cruel.

The victim who decides that the Christian faith is finally not credible has been given enormous reason to decide it, and so the question for the serious pastor is not whether that reason is sufficient — the question is whether the church responded the way it should have. In most cases, it did not.

THE INSTITUTIONAL REFLEX: WHY CHURCHES PROTECT THEMSELVES AND COVER UP ABUSE

This pattern is not a feature of particular denominations or networks; it is a feature of the institution itself, because every human institution exposed to the possibility of a sexual scandal instinctively prioritizes its own survival over the vulnerable. The church is not the exception it claimed to be. The body that said it was held to a higher standard has failed that standard as predictably as every other institution has.

The public cases that shaped the deconstruction wave are names the reader already knows: Ravi Zacharias, whose decades of apologetics covered decades of sexual predation that the institution he built knew about, or should have; Bill Hybels, whose Willow Creek spent years absorbing and then denying credible allegations; the Southern Baptist Convention, whose 2022 investigation revealed a pattern of institutional cover-up stretching across hundreds of cases. To these belong the individual pastors in every major network whose names became cautionary tales for a generation that watched the reveals in real time, watched the responses, and drew its conclusions.

*She is watching an institution that
knows it has failed, knows it must
change, and is choosing, at the
moment of decision, to protect itself
rather than the vulnerable.*

One can argue that the conclusion overgeneralizes, and one can point to the faithful pastors and the healthy congregations that do not fit the pattern; these arguments are not false. But they do not answer the deeper question — whether the institution that produced the failures is capable of the reforms that would prevent their recurrence, and whether it is even telling the truth about the failures it has already acknowledged — and on both counts the evidence is mixed at best. The Southern Baptist response to its own investigation was slower and weaker than the findings warranted, the proposed accountability

WHAT A LOCAL PASTOR CAN DO: FIVE STRUCTURES OF ACCOUNTABILITY AND PROTECTION

The national patterns lie beyond any one pastor's control, but the local church does not — and five things are within reach, each of which costs something.

First, name the crisis from the pulpit, in specific terms rather than generalities: say the names of the institutions that failed, say the patterns by which they failed, say that those failures are the reason some of the congregation's own children have left the faith, and do not soften the saying. The young person in the room needs to hear, from the pulpit, that the person in the pulpit sees what she sees — and that hearing is the precondition for everything else.

Second, build concrete accountability into the congregation, the kind that does not depend on anyone's good character: background checks on everyone in children's and youth ministry; two-adult rules without exception; a credible process for reporting concerns that does not route through the pastor who might be the problem; a standing relationship with outside, trauma-informed counselors; a written policy on how allegations will be handled, biased toward believing the vulnerable and committed to involving civil authorities in any suspected crime; and a willingness to share information with other congregations when a leader leaves under

Third, develop a pastoral theology of trauma adequate to what the victim actually carries. She does not need to be told to pray harder; she needs a trauma-informed therapist she can afford, a congregation that can sit with her through the slow work of healing without timelines and without pressure to produce the expected breakthroughs, and a church that can say plainly — we were part of the system that hurt you, even if neither of us was the specific actor, and we are sorry. She needs permission to have a complicated relationship with prayer, with worship, with Scripture, for as long as that complexity takes, and she needs to know that her return to the faith, if it comes, will not be required to keep the schedule the congregation would prefer. The church that can offer these things has a chance of keeping her; the church that cannot will lose her, and lose her permanently.

Fourth, do not defend the indefensible. When a major evangelical figure falls, and the fall is confirmed, do not construct elaborate reasons why his teaching can still be relied on, do not suggest his accusers had political motives, and do not deflect to the sins of progressive Christians as though the comparison excused the failure — confess it, say it cost the church dearly, say the institution's response fell short and say what must change, even at the cost of friendships with pastors who are still in the defensive crouch. The young person is listening, and

Fifth, teach a doctrine of authority that does not place pastors or elders beyond challenge, because the New Testament model of eldership is plural, accountable, and servant-shaped rather than monarchical: Paul expected elders to be corrected, Peter was rebuked to his face, and the congregation was never passive material for the leaders to shape but a body that carried the Spirit and was capable, under the Spirit, of discerning when its leaders had gone wrong. Restoring this is no concession to modern egalitarianism. It is a return to what the New Testament actually teaches, and it is the structural precondition for any church that intends not to repeat the abuses it confesses.

TO THE ONE WHO WAS HARMED

Some readers of this page were the victim, and the words here cannot do what the presence of a safe human being could do better, and they will not presume otherwise — but this much can be said plainly: the instincts were trustworthy, and the wrongness that was felt was real wrongness.

The silence that surrounded the wrongness was a second injury, and the institution that failed to protect the victim failed the God it claimed to serve, not the other way around. The victim's faith, or whatever remains of it, is not the thing on trial here. The institution is. To have left the church because one could not stay inside the institution that did the harm is not failure; it is accurate observation of the world that was presented. There are Christians, and

THE WORK THAT WILL HOLD: GUARDRAILS AGAINST THE ABUSE OF POWER

A word, too, for the pastor who is no victim but who lives close to the culture that produces abuse — examine the habits, and examine them honestly. Is there a personality cult running without its leader's knowledge? Are there people afraid to disagree? Does the staff meeting hold any real disagreement, or has disagreement been punished until it quietly disappeared? Are the accountability relationships actually accountable, or are they with men who owe favors and will not push when it counts?

The abusive pastor is rarely a monster who entered ministry to hurt people; he is, in most cases, a man who began with real conviction and then, over decades, let the small compromises of power accumulate, unchallenged, until the compromises were the whole person. No one is immune, which is exactly why the guardrails are the point. Install them. Trust them. Let them do their work.

The reckoning is not over, and it is not close to over — the investigations that reshaped the Southern Baptist

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Doubt as Devotion

*Doubt as a Form of Faith — the Psalms of Lament,
Job, Habakkuk, the Dark Night of the Soul, and
Why Questioning Is Not the Opposite of Believing*

The deconstruction wave has made one contribution to American Christian life worth naming as a gift rather than a threat, and it is this: it has forced the church to speak about doubt in a way the church has mostly refused to. For a generation, evangelical preaching treated doubt as a problem to be solved, a weakness to be confessed, a symptom of a life not fully surrendered — and so the doubters sat in the pews and listened to sermons about the doubters as though the doubters were some other, outside population, and they learned to hide. They learned to say amen when they did not feel amen, to sing songs of confident faith they did not have, to perform belief in order to remain acceptable. The performance was never going to hold, and when it broke, the breaking looked like apostasy. It was not apostasy. It was the end of the performance.

Doubt, rightly understood, is not the opposite of faith; it is often the form faith takes in a mind that is thinking, and

THE PRAYER BOOK OF THE PEOPLE OF GOD: THE PSALMS OF LAMENT AND HONEST DOUBT

The psalms are where the church has the most room to recover the theology of doubt it lost, because the book of Psalms is the prayer book of the people of God — it was the prayer book of Jesus — and at a conservative estimate it is one-third complaint and one-third lament. The singers of these psalms are not theological novices, not weak faith, not people in need of correction by some confident senior saint; they are the core of the worshiping tradition, and the core of the worshiping tradition spent a great portion of its praying life in complaint.

How long, O Lord? Will you forget me forever? How long will you hide your face from me?

— PSALM 13:1

That is not a warm-up to the real faith; that is the faith.

A church that cannot pray Psalm 13 without editing it has not understood the faith it claims to have inherited, and a church that skips the laments in its services, or softens them into generic confessions of struggle, has taken from its people the one prayer language they need most when they need any prayer at all. The deconstructor who was told to stop doubting and start trusting was handed advice the psalmist would not recognize, because the psalmist trusts by doubting out loud in the presence of the One he doubts. That is the model. Lose the model, and the people no longer know how to stay in relationship with God through the dark seasons, because no one ever taught them that the relationship includes the dark.

THE QUESTIONS SCRIPTURE REFUSES TO RESOLVE: HABAKKUK, JOB, AND UNANSWERED FAITH

Habakkuk goes further. The prophet opens with a complaint that God is doing nothing about the injustice in Judah, and God answers, eventually, that he will indeed do something — he will bring the Babylonians to sack the country — at which point Habakkuk's response is a second complaint, longer and more specific than the first: you will use the Babylonians to discipline us, but the Babylonians are worse than we are, so how can the Holy One use the unholy as his instrument? The prophet holds that

God's answer is not a refutation of the question; it is a promise that the righteous will live by faith, and a vision in which God's character is shown to be worth trusting even when the mechanisms stay hidden. At the end Habakkuk says it plainly:

*Though the fig tree should not blossom, nor fruit be
on the vines, the produce of the olive fail and the
fields yield no food, yet I will rejoice in the Lord.*

– HABAKKUK 3:17-18

That is not the resolution of the question; it is a decision, made inside the unresolved question, to keep trusting the character of the God whose ways remain a mystery. The question is never answered — the prophet is answered — and this is what mature faith often looks like in Scripture: not faith without questions, but faith inside the questions, making its decisions about trust on the basis of the God it already knows from the long history of God's dealings, even when the present dealing makes no sense. The deconstructor told that faith requires the absence of questions has been handed a simulation of faith, not the thing itself. The thing itself is more rugged. It survives hard questions because it was built for them.

Job is the same case carried into the courtroom: thirty-seven chapters of dialogue between Job and his comforters, who defend a theological system Job will not accept — and he will not accept it because it does not match his experience, and because it asks him to confess sins he did not commit in order to rescue God's reputation. Job declines the rescue, and at the end God vindicates him against the comforters: they have not

*God prefers the honest complaint that
refuses to explain him to the dishonest
piety that protects a system at the cost
of the truth.*

The contemporary American evangelical church is full of comforters — full of people who will assure the doubter that God has a plan, that everything will work out, that the suffering is building character, that the doubter simply needs to trust. These comforters are not always wrong; sometimes they are right. But when they are right, they are right by accident, because the method is wrong: the method is to defend God's reputation by explaining God's ways, and the book of Job is on record that this is exactly the method that offends him. God does not need defending by explanations the doubter experiences as lies. He prefers, Job says, the truthful complaint that leaves the question open.

Not every expression of doubt is automatically legitimate faith, because some doubt is intellectual laziness and some is a mask for something else — for moral resistance to a teaching the doubter does not want to obey, for cultural pressure the doubter has not examined. Faithful pastoral work distinguishes the doubt that is seeking truth from the doubt that is avoiding it, and the distinction is rarely easy; pastors err in both directions. The pastor who calls every doubt legitimate has flattened the category and will fail the person who needs to be challenged, while the pastor who calls every doubt illegitimate has absolutized the category and will crush the person who needs to be received.

The test is not primarily doctrinal; it is postural. The doubter who is seeking truth keeps showing up, keeps asking, keeps reading, keeps praying in the half-light, while the doubter who is avoiding truth stops showing up, stops asking, stops reading, stops praying, and reaches instead for the lifestyle the doubt has opened. Both may use the same vocabulary of deconstruction, but they are, in fact, two different phenomena: the first is faith in process, and the second is something else. A good pastor watches which one is in front of him and responds accordingly — the first needs companionship, the second a loving confrontation.

**THE DARK NIGHT HAS A NAME: WHEN
GOD FEELS ABSENT BUT FAITH
REMAINS**

The mystics who wrote about it — John of the Cross, Teresa of Avila, Thomas Merton — insisted that this condition, unpleasant as it is, is often a sign of progress rather than regression: the believer is being weaned from reliance on the emotional by-products of faith so that she can come to rest in the God who is there even when the by-products are gone. This is a gift the church can give a certain kind of deconstructor, because the person who says, I used to feel God's presence and now I feel nothing, so I must have lost the faith, is often the person who is, in fact, in a dark night. The felt presence was never the faith; it was a gracious support God gives new believers and sometimes takes from maturing ones, and its absence does not indicate the absence of God. It can indicate a deepening of the relationship, now asked to grow up into something less dependent on felt reassurance.

Mother Teresa lived most of her adult life in this condition; the letters published after her death show a woman who worked among the dying in Calcutta for five decades while feeling nothing whatsoever of the God she served. Her superiors, when she confided it, affirmed her — the condition was consistent with her calling, and the

A THEOLOGY OF DOUBT: WHY HONEST QUESTIONS BELONG INSIDE THE FAITH

Set out as a positive proposal rather than only a corrective, a theology of doubt begins with the recognition that God is greater than the mind's capacity to comprehend him — and this is not evasion but one of the oldest confessions of the tradition. God is not an object in the universe, available for inventory the way a chair or a planet is; he is the ground of being, the source from which all finite things come, the mystery at the center of existence, which means talk about God is always partial, always analogical, always bounded by the limits of the creaturely mind attempting it. Doubt, honestly faced, is often the creaturely mind meeting its limits and being rightly humbled by them, and that encounter is closer to worship than to apostasy.

It continues with the recognition that Scripture itself carries the doubting voices and honors them — Job, Ecclesiastes, the laments, the anger of Jeremiah, who accused God of seducing him, the confused silence of the disciples after the crucifixion, and the cry of dereliction

| *My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?*

— MARK 15:34

This is not decoration on the Bible; it is the center of it, because the center of the Christian faith is a moment of the Son putting to the Father a question the text never answers. The answer is not given — it is embodied, three days later, in the resurrection — but the question stands, and the tradition has always, at its best, held the question as part of the faith. The traditions that erased it gave their people a lighter faith, and the lighter faith does not survive the hard night. The heavier one, which carries the question with it, does.

Finally, a theology of doubt grounds itself in the person of Jesus Christ, because the doubter is not asked to believe a system; the doubter is asked to keep looking at Jesus in the Gospels and to say what he actually sees. If Jesus, after a long look, still compels, then the doubter still has a faith, even when every doctrinal position he once held is now in motion — for faith in Christ is more durable than faith in the system that interpreted Christ. The system has often been wrong. Christ remains. The doubter who has lost confidence in the system and still cannot stop looking at Christ is not a failed believer; he is, in some ways, more clearly a believer than many who hold the system with confidence but have not looked at Christ in years.

WHAT THE PASTOR DOES WITH THIS: PREACHING AND HONORING DOUBT

First, preach the doubting Scriptures: give a sermon series to the psalms of lament, preach through Job — not only the

Second, make space for expressed doubt by holding conversations in small groups structured around the questions rather than around the approved answers, and train lay leaders to host those conversations without defensiveness. Let the doubter discover, in a Christian setting, that the question she thought would get her exiled is received instead as a legitimate form of inquiry — that experience alone can restore years of lost trust.

Third, do not rush the resolution, because the doubter is on a schedule that is not the pastor's: some questions take decades to settle, and some are never settled on this side. The faithful posture toward the doubter is patience. The church that expected every question to resolve by next Tuesday has failed many doubters, while the church that can walk with one for five years without pressuring resolution has a chance of keeping her.

Fourth, model honest doubt, within limits, because the pastor who pretends never to have doubted anything is not credible and imitates no saint in church history, whereas the pastor who shares with discernment from his own seasons of aridity and unresolved question gives the congregation permission to have the same. The sharing has to be careful — the pulpit is not the place to process a current crisis — but the pulpit is the place to tell the congregation, truthfully, that faith has seasons, that some of them are dark, and that the God who met his people in

Fifth, tell the doubter out loud that her continued place in the congregation does not depend on arriving at specific conclusions by specific dates; tell her she is honored by her presence whether her questions ever fully resolve or not; tell her the church is not a fraternity requiring agreement on a password but a family that loves its members through whatever they are carrying. This telling alone can keep her for years, and the lack of it will, predictably, lose her.

The church that learns to honor doubt will not become a church of doubters; it will become a church of people whose faith has been tested and who have remained — because the testing is not a bug, the testing is how faith grows up. The smooth, untested faith that never considered the hard questions is brittle, and it shatters on impact, while the weathered faith that held the questions for years, prayed through the dark nights, accepted the limits of its own understanding, and continued anyway is the faith that can carry a life. That is the faith the deconstructor is looking for. Most of them will not say so; most will say they are looking for honesty, or for a church not afraid of their questions, or for a place where they can breathe — and these are the same thing, described from the outside. Offer it. The ones who can be kept will be kept.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Reconstruction

*How to Reconstruct Your Faith After
Deconstruction — Recovering the Great
Tradition, Spiritual Practice, Community, and a
Faith That Holds*

One word has swallowed the conversation while the other has barely found its footing: deconstruction is everywhere, and reconstruction is an afterthought — and that is a problem, because deconstruction on its own is only half a process. To pull something apart without knowing how to build anything is not arrival; it is a stalled engine. Much of the deconstruction wave has stalled exactly there, not because the people inside it lacked the will to move, but because the only map they were handed described the demolition and nothing past it. What does faith look like on the far side? The answer differs from person to person, and it asks one thing of the reader before it gives anything back: courage.

Not every deconstruction ends the same way. Some who deconstruct become atheists or agnostics, having concluded that the supernatural frame does not survive

RECOVERING THE GREAT TRADITION: THE TWO-THOUSAND-YEAR FAITH BEYOND EVANGELICALISM

The first piece is the recovery of the Great Tradition — the broad stream of Christian thought and practice that predates the modern period and forms the shared inheritance of Catholics, Orthodox, and historic Protestants: the Apostles' Creed and the Nicene Creed, the seven ecumenical councils, the liturgical year, the sacraments, and the disciplines of prayer, fasting, silence, and Scripture meditation the church has kept, in one form or another, since its earliest centuries.

Many American evangelical deconstructors were never introduced to any of it, and so, assuming American

So begin by reading it — Augustine's Confessions, Athanasius on the incarnation, Julian of Norwich, Bonaventure, Thomas Aquinas at least in summary, the Philokalia from the Orthodox stream, Thomas à Kempis, George Herbert, Bonhoeffer, Marilynne Robinson. These are not extras; they are the spine of the faith one may have thought he left, and they are still here, patient, waiting to be noticed. Read them and a discovery often follows: many of the questions that made evangelicalism unsupportable are not questions these writers share, because they lived inside a faith with different loads on it, different emphases, different habits — a Christianity continuous with the reader's and yet not identical to the one that exhausted him. That discovery alone can reopen the possibility of faith.

**RECOVERING PRACTICE: HOW
SPIRITUAL DISCIPLINES REBUILD A
FAITH**

The Great Tradition has always held faith together with practice: you pray the daily office, you fast on appointed days, you keep the liturgical year, you receive the sacraments, you perform acts of mercy, you practice hospitality — because a person is formed by what he does, not only by what he thinks, and that formation is the point. Belief is sustained by practice more than by argument; regular prayer, kept over years, forms someone who finds God in the practice itself, even while the beliefs are still in motion.

The deconstructor looking for something that will hold her does not need, first, a better apologetic. She needs a practice — and she needs a trustworthy director or pastor or friend to hand her a short list and say: do these, for a year, without worrying whether you believe them. Pray the Lord's Prayer every morning, read one psalm a day, take communion weekly if a church will let you, even when you are unsure of everything around it; keep a Sabbath, give a tenth of your income to causes you respect, volunteer consistently at one institution that serves the vulnerable in your city, and confess your real sins — not the generic ones — to one trusted human being. Sustained, these practices change the person doing them, and over time they do something to the beliefs that sit above them: the beliefs clarify, some fall away, some deepen. The process will not

RECOVERING COMMUNITY AND INTELLECT: FINDING A CHURCH AND READING BEYOND THE BUBBLE

The third piece is the recovery of a communal frame, because Christianity is not a private enterprise: it has always been, at its core, a communal faith, and the attempts to practice it alone have generally failed. Sooner or later the deconstructor seeking a reconstruction that holds will have to find a community.

This is hard. The community he came from is often the very thing he is still processing, the alternatives look off-putting — too conservative or too progressive, too formal or too casual — and walking into an unfamiliar tradition is uncomfortable; it is necessary anyway. No one reconstructs the faith alone in his kitchen. It takes other bodies in a room, praying and singing and serving alongside, over years, until the practice becomes the person.

The community you find does not have to be the one you end in, and many on this path passed through several congregations before they settled. The deconstructor who tries an Anglican parish, finds it useful for a season, then sits through a Catholic mass and finds it more than she expected, then lands in a liturgical Lutheran congregation that fits her, has not been unstable — she has been searching with discernment, and discernment takes time.

The fourth piece is the recovery of an intellectual architecture equal to the actual weight of the questions. Mainstream evangelicalism tends to operate with a thin toolkit — worldview apologetics, proof texts, a small canon of authorized thinkers who broadly agree — so that when the questions grow larger the toolkit gives out, and the deconstructor concludes the faith itself has run out of resources. It has not. The faith has vast resources; he has been working inside a small subset.

To widen it, read outside the subset: the Catholic philosophers — Alasdair MacIntyre, Charles Taylor, James K. A. Smith; the Orthodox theologians — John Zizioulas, David Bentley Hart, Frederica Mathewes-Green; the mainline Protestant heavyweights — Karl Barth, Dietrich Bonhoeffer, Stanley Hauerwas, Fleming Rutledge; the contemporary evangelicals doing serious intellectual work — N. T. Wright, Richard Hays, Miroslav Volf, Esau McCaulley. They do not all agree, and the reader will not agree with all of them, but they supply categories the thin toolkit never offered, and together they show that the faith is more durable, more interesting, and more able to bear intellectual weight than the evangelicalism he left ever

RECOVERING TIME, SUFFERING, AND OBEDIENCE: THE LONG VIEW AND THE FREELY CHOSEN YES

The fifth piece is the recovery of a long view of time. Because it is young, American evangelicalism keeps a short memory: it speaks of the early church and has the creeds at hand, but its felt horizon is the last forty years, so that something is judged successful when the pastor's podcast grows and judged true when the contemporary consensus affirms it.

That short horizon makes the tradition feel less stable than it is, because when the consensus shifts — as it does every decade or two — the person whose only frame is the present consensus feels the ground move. The reconstructive path requires a longer horizon: learning to read the church across centuries rather than across recent podcasts, developing an instinct for which claims the church has held in every time and place and which are merely the particular enthusiasms of the current North American moment. That instinct is the antidote to both the reactive traditionalism that rejects everything new and the rootless progressivism that swallows whatever the consensus says, and it is formed slowly, by reading widely and thinking across centuries.

The sixth piece is the recovery of suffering as a category of Christian experience that is not, first of all, a problem to be solved. The evangelical frame often treats suffering as an anomaly — why would a good God let this happen? — but the Great Tradition treats it as central: the cross stands at the heart of the faith, the martyrs are

The seventh piece, and the one many find hardest, is the recovery of obedience. Somewhere in deconstruction, obedience gets pushed to the margin, and with good reason: the deconstructor has come to distrust the authorities that demanded it and to see the demand itself as manipulation. But over time a faith without any obedience becomes indistinguishable from a lifestyle preference, and the reconstructive path eventually requires the rediscovery of the yes — not the yes coerced by abusive authority, not the yes that comes from wanting to belong to a tribe.

*The yes that says: I have looked at the
teachings of Jesus, and at the
alternatives my culture offers, and I
would rather live inside his teachings,
with all their cost, than inside the*

That yes, chosen freely, against the grain of the surrounding culture, is what the church in every age has meant by faith. The deconstructor who reaches it has not returned to the starting point; she has arrived at something the starting point could never have produced, because the starting point had not yet been tested.

WHAT THE CHURCH OWES THE RECONSTRUCTOR: MENTORS, PRACTICE, AND PATIENCE

A word about the timeline, because this is a long process — not the six-week course a church sometimes offers to bring the deconstructor back, but years: a reading list, a search for community, a practice of disciplines, the building of intellectual resources, the cultivation of the long view, the reframing of suffering, and the eventual rediscovery of obedience. Most who make it through will say it took five to ten years, and the church that wants them back has to be willing to stay present for the whole of it without demanding accelerated milestones. Most churches are not willing. Be the exception.

And a word about what the church owes the reconstructor, as distinct from the deconstructor. The deconstructor needs space, acknowledgment, and patience; the reconstructor, the one building on the other side, needs more active resources — reading recommendations, a mentor, a liturgy and a practice and a community that can carry the weight of the faith she is

End with a single image. A woman who went through a long and painful deconstruction after spiritual abuse in her childhood church said that what finally held her was not one conversation or one book — it was a small Anglican parish that let her sit in the back during compline every Sunday night for two years before she spoke a word to anyone. She did not join, she did not profess faith, she did not tithe; she sat in the back, during the hour when the rest of the world was running, and let the prayers and the candles and the Psalms do their slow work. After two years she asked the priest whether they could talk through some questions, and he said, yes, and I am glad you came back. He did not say, where have you been; he did not say, what took you so long; he said, I am glad you came back. They talked for a year, and then she asked to be baptized, because her childhood baptism felt too entangled with what had been done to her, and the priest, after due discernment, said yes. She was baptized at the Easter Vigil, thirty-five years old, and at the reception afterward, to the small group of friends who had come to witness it, she said: I never thought I would stand in a church again. Here I am.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

The Church We Could Still Become

A Vision for a Healthier Church — Truth-Telling, Accountability, Liturgical Depth, a Theology of Suffering, and a Faith Worth Coming Back To

Fifteen chapters have named what went wrong and what an honest answer to it requires, and what remains is to describe the congregation that could result — one that took the diagnosis seriously and built its common life around the response. This is not a utopia, and it is not a model that fits every context; it is a composite sketch, drawn from congregations worth visiting, pastors worth learning from, and the imperfect work of churches that have been at it for years. The sketch is encouragement, not prescription. Take what is useful, leave what is not, and build what the people in front of you actually need.

**A CHURCH THAT TELLS THE TRUTH
ABOUT ITSELF: NAMING FAILURES
INSTEAD OF BRANDING**

It names the failures, and it names them specifically — the abuse cover-ups, the political captivity, the financial scandals, the purity culture that wounded a generation, a doctrine of hell preached more vividly than the love of Christ, the flag in the sanctuary — and it names these not as rhetorical throat-clearing but as the actual conditions under which it is attempting to rebuild.

Truth-telling of this kind is not a single confession; it is a culture — the way the pastor speaks every week, the way the elders operate, the way the members are trained to talk about their own church. So when the young adult who comes back for the first Sunday in six years, hesitant and half-expecting the old evasions, hears the pulpit say something true about Ravi Zacharias, or the Southern Baptist report, or the last election, she feels something she has not felt in a sanctuary in a long time: that the pulpit is standing in the same world she is. That feeling will do more than every outreach campaign the church has ever run.

**A CHURCH WITH STRUCTURES, NOT
SLOGANS: BUILDING REAL**

The second mark is structural accountability, because a church that has told the truth has, by that very telling, exposed itself to a question it cannot dodge: how will it keep the failures from recurring? The question does not answer itself, and it is not answered by slogans or by prayers offered in place of policy. It is answered by structures.

Such a church publishes how allegations of misconduct will be handled, and the procedure does not route through the accused but through an independent party, external to the staff and the eldership, whose task is to investigate; it runs background checks on everyone in children's and youth ministry; it enforces a two-adult rule, with consequences for violation; it sets a conflict-of-interest policy covering the pastor's compensation, travel, and outside income; it places term limits on elders so that no single faction becomes entrenched; it submits its finances to outside review every year; and it names an ombudsperson to whom any member can carry a concern without first passing it through the very person the concern is about.

None of this is exotic — it is ordinary, and it costs nothing but humility — which is exactly why the refusal to adopt it is itself a confession of what a church actually values.

A CHURCH WITH LITURGICAL DEPTH: RECOVERING WORSHIP THAT CAN CARRY WEIGHT

The third mark is liturgical depth, because the church that

It keeps the calendar — Advent, Christmas, Epiphany, Lent, Easter, Pentecost, Ordinary Time — not because the calendar is magic, but because it gives the year a shape not dictated by the retail season or the sports schedule; and so the year takes its form from the story of Christ, and the congregation learns, without quite noticing the lesson, that the story of Christ is the story it lives inside.

Many American evangelicals received a worship that had carefully removed these elements, on the unspoken theory that they were Catholic, or high church, or dead religion — but they are none of those things. They are the worship of the church across two thousand years; the contemporary service that stripped them out is the innovation, and the elements are the tradition. Restoring them is not a retreat into formality at the expense of life; it is a recovery of the forms that have, in every age, proved able to carry the faith through upheaval. The years ahead will demand worship that can carry weight, and the praise band and the teachable moment are lighter forms than what is coming will require.

A CHURCH THAT TEACHES THE FAITH:

The fourth mark is catechesis — a word most evangelicals have not spoken in a hundred years, meaning simply the structured teaching of the faith to people who want to learn it — and it is a mark made necessary because the American evangelical church largely assumed faith would be absorbed by osmosis, from services and youth groups and small groups and family devotions. The assumption did not hold.

The generation raised in evangelical households absorbed something, but it was not the faith; it was a set of cultural markers, a handful of verses, a reflex of partisan loyalty, and a vague conviction that God wants them happy, while the faith itself, as a structured body of belief and practice, was never handed over. That is a catechetical failure, and the church we could become takes it seriously.

It writes a catechism, or adopts a historic one, or works through a classic like the Heidelberg or Luther's Small Catechism, and it asks every new member, whatever their age, to spend a year inside it before joining; it does the same with its teenagers, so that the confirmation class becomes not a rite of passage but a year of serious engagement with the historic faith — the creeds, the sacraments, the Lord's Prayer, the Ten Commandments, the Beatitudes, the central doctrines, and the practices that have sustained Christians through hard times. The graduates are not certified theologians, but they are formed in a way most American evangelicals never were, and they will be able to hold, under pressure, what a thinner formation would have let slip.

A CHURCH WITH A REAL THEOLOGY OF

The fifth mark is a real theology of suffering, and a church that teaches one will, by the same curriculum, disarm the prosperity reflex that has crept into every corner of American Christianity — including the corners that would reject the prosperity gospel by name. The reflex assumes that if a person is faithful, things will work out, and that assumption is not biblical. It is American.

Preaching it out, week by week, over years, will cost the preacher something, because the congregation will not love, at first, the sermons that tell the truth about what the Christian life actually costs — and the instruction is to stay with it anyway, since the congregation that receives a faith with its full weight in the picture becomes more durable under pressure, more able to sit with suffering neighbors, and more recognizable as the church of Jesus Christ than the congregation down the road still promising that God has a plan and everything will be fine.

Scripture never made the lighter promise; the man it calls a man of sorrows knew what it asked:

He was despised and rejected by men, a man of sorrows, and acquainted with grief.

— ISAIAH 53:3

A CHURCH THAT MAKES ROOM BEYOND THE NUCLEAR FAMILY: SINGLENESSE, FRIENDSHIP, AND BELONGING

The sixth mark is a reimagined account of friendship, singleness, and family, because for generations the American evangelical church has centered the nuclear

The New Testament does not teach this. Jesus, Paul, and most of the early church's missionary leadership were single, and the church they built was a family that exceeded biological family — it was where the childless woman found mothering to do, where the orphan found fathers and brothers, where the person with no blood kin found kin.

A congregation that recovers this builds durable practices of friendship: it hosts meals that bring single adults and families together as equals — participants, not guests; it treats celibacy as a vocation the church needs, not a consolation prize for those who did not marry; and it teaches sexual ethics in a way that includes single adults, gay Christians who hold the traditional ethic, widows, the divorced, and married couples, without making anyone feel assigned to a lesser version of the faith. It does not assume the highest good of a person is marriage and children; it assumes the highest good is union with Christ, lived out in community, in whatever shape of life God has given. In that congregation the single adult, the gay Christian, the childless couple, and the divorced mother do not feel tolerated. They feel at home, because they are.

A CHURCH UNAFRAID OF ITS OWN MIND: WELCOMING HARD QUESTIONS

Such a church also takes the intellectual life of its

This is not intellectualism in the bad sense; it is not pretension, and it is not credentialing. It is a congregation that believes its faith is true, that the truth of the faith can bear scrutiny, that scrutiny is therefore welcome, and that the life of the mind belongs to the love of God with heart, soul, mind, and strength. The church that has feared its own mind has bred Christians who cannot hold a conversation with an unbelieving colleague, a skeptical child, or a doubting spouse; the church that has trained its mind breeds Christians who can speak of their faith without flinching, because they have, in fact, thought about it.

A CHURCH THAT NEITHER RETREATS NOR CONQUERS: A POSTURE TOWARD THE WORLD BEYOND THE CULTURE WAR

The seventh mark is a posture toward the world that is neither retreat nor conquest, because for a century the American evangelical church has oscillated between two unhealthy stances. The first is retreat: circling the wagons, treating the broader culture as the enemy, raising children

Neither is the posture of Christ, who was no monastic and no political operative but a rabbi who walked into the villages, sat at the tables of the unrighteous, told the truth, suffered for it, and rose from the dead. His followers have been most faithful when they lived as residents of the kingdom of God inside the kingdom of this world — neither fleeing it nor seeking to rule it, present in it as witnesses, servants, friends, neighbors, and when necessary, martyrs.

The congregation that recovers this is engaged with its city, its schools, its social wounds, its homeless and addicted and abused and bereaved — not to win, not to look good, not to run a program, but because its Lord is engaged, and where the Lord goes, the church follows. Its politics are not the politics of a party; they are the politics of the Sermon on the Mount, applied with discernment, matching neither coalition evenly, critical of both, loyal to Christ, loving its enemies, refusing to hate. That posture will make enemies in every tribe.

*The congregation that can absorb the
hatred of every tribe and still love the
enemies who send it is recognizably
the church of Jesus Christ. The
congregation adopted by one tribe and*

A CHURCH WITH GENERATIONAL PATIENCE: MEASURING BY FIDELITY, NOT GROWTH

The eighth mark is generational patience, for the church we could become does not expect to reverse the cultural slide in five years, does not expect all its children to return, and does not expect its community to notice its faithfulness. It is playing a long game it may lose, in its current institutional form, within its own lifetime — and it is content to lose that game, because it knows the game it is actually playing is not scored on those stakes.

The real work is handing on the faith, faithfully, to whatever remnant will receive it, and trusting the Spirit with the rest; such a church is prepared to become smaller, poorer, less visible, and it is also prepared, if the Spirit wills, to become an unexpected source of life for a generation that gave up on the institutions it left. Either way, it does not measure itself by growth, influence, or relevance — the metrics that ruined so many of its peers. It measures itself by fidelity.

Say it plainly: the churches that survive the next forty years in anything like a recognizable Christian form will not be the ones that ran the largest conferences, produced the most popular podcasts, or held the most political power at their peak; they will be the ones that did the

A CHURCH THAT LOVES THE ONES WHO LEFT: THE FATHER ON THE PORCH

The ninth mark is love for the people who have left — the one the church has forgotten and the one the deconstructor most needs to hear — and the church we could become does not write them off. It does not file them under apostate or cautionary tale, it does not speak of them as lost causes or as enemies, but instead it holds them: it prays for them by name, it welcomes them back, whenever and if they return, without demanding that they explain themselves, account for what they missed, or perform the testimony that would close the loop. It sits with them in their unbelief, it remembers them on Sunday, and it is the father on the porch, every evening, watching the road.

The deconstructor reading this may be thinking that there has never been a church like the one described here, and two things are worth saying. First, this church exists in fragments and approximations, in scattered places, and it is possible to find one — so try again, because not every church is the church that was left. Second, where it cannot be found, it can be built; the person who walked away from a broken institution because it was broken is under no

The shortage of trustworthy churches will not fix itself; it will be repaired, if it is repaired, by people who have seen what is wrong and who carry the conviction, the pain, and the residual faith to help build the alternative. To such a person the church says: it has not treated you well, and it is asking anyway whether you will come back — not to the institution that hurt you, but to the Lord who has not stopped loving you — and whether, as part of that return, you will lend a hand to the slow work of making the next version of the institution less hurtful and more faithful.

This is the church we could still become. It is not a church of the future; it is a church that, in scattered forms, has always existed in the history of the Christian people, and that is laboring to be born again in this generation, in the aftermath of a collapse that was, in many ways, the judgment of God on what the church had made of itself. Judgment is not the last word — in the biblical imagination judgment is the prelude to mercy, and collapse is the prelude to whatever comes next — and what comes next depends, in part, on what the remnant does with the materials it has been handed and the hour it has been given. The materials exist. The only open question is whether there is courage enough to take them up.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Parents of Deconstructors

*When Your Adult Child Leaves the Faith —
Counsel for Parents on Guilt, the Relationship,
Prayer, and Loving a Child Who No Longer
Believes*

You are the largest group of readers this book has, and the one most often left out of the conversation — present only as a cautionary tale or a sympathy case, never as the person actually in the room. You are neither of those things. You are, in many instances, a person of deep faith carrying a grief that has no obvious vocabulary and no clear resolution, and you have carried it quietly because the language for it does not exist. You did what you knew to do: you took the children to church, you did the devotions, you prayed the prayers, you paid for the Christian school or modeled the family altar or led the youth group or hosted the small group on Tuesday nights — and then you watched your child grow up, profess faith, maybe even get baptized, and then, in high school or in college or in the

The child is not always angry. Sometimes the child is kind — still calls, still shows up at Christmas, simply does not believe anymore, or does not believe the way you believe. And you are left holding a question with no answer you can accept: what did I do wrong, what could I have done differently, am I being judged for a failure I cannot even see. The grief is always the same and the specifics are always different, because every family is its own country with its own history, and the specifics matter more than any general counsel can honor. What follows is meant to help you stand inside this situation without breaking.

YOUR CHILD'S DECONSTRUCTION IS NOT A VERDICT ON YOU: LETTING GO OF THE GUILT AND PROVERBS 22:6

In most cases it is not the indictment of your parenting that you are reading it as — and you are reading it that way because evangelical culture trained you to, teaching you that if you did your job the child would walk with the Lord, teaching you that a single verse was a guarantee:

*Train up a child in the way he should go, and when
he is old he will not depart from it.*

— PROVERBS 22:6

That verse is a general principle about how character is formed, not a promise that faithful parenting secures a child's faith; the teaching that turned it into a promise was Americanized pragmatism dressed in biblical language — the prosperity gospel applied to the family, where the right inputs are owed the right outputs. The actual biblical picture is more complicated and far less reassuring, and it

You are not Samuel, and you are not David, and you are also not — thank God — required to be; you are a parent who did your best inside your limits, whose child, being an adult now, is making her own decisions, and those decisions do not belong to you and never were going to. The notion that you could guarantee her faith by the sheer quality of your parenting was a fantasy, and the guilt it has been manufacturing in you all this time is not from the Lord, who has a long record of working patiently with people whose parents were terrible and whose children were worse, and who is working patiently with yours. Let him.

THE RELATIONSHIP OUTWEIGHS THE POSITION: LOVING YOUR CHILD WITHOUT MANAGING THEIR BELIEF

Your relationship with your child matters more than her current theology — which can sound like the kind of thing said to soften your conviction, and it is not. The thing you have, and can maintain, and can build on, is the relationship; the thing you cannot control, and must not try to manage, is her belief. Spend your energy on the first, and save your theological energy for your own spiritual

This is harder than it sounds. You will sit through Thanksgiving dinners while the child's new boyfriend says things about religion you know to be false, and you will bite your tongue; you will hear, from your own child, criticisms of the church you have loved for fifty years, and in some cases you will have to agree with them even when the agreement costs you; you will welcome her home without treating her like a project, without the scheduled pointed conversation, without introducing the visiting pastor with a meaningful look. Every instinct you were trained in will pull the other way — and you will have to resist every one of them, out of love for the person in front of you, who is your child and not a theological case study.

Adjust the clock while you are at it, because the years may be longer than you are used to imagining: deconstruction takes time, and for your child the timeline may be five years, or ten, or twenty. If you have been quietly assuming this is a phase that passes by next Christmas, you will not make it through with your soul intact — you will burn out on hope, then burn out on despair, then settle into a low-grade resentment that

KEEP PRAYING, BUT CHANGE THE PRAYER: PRAYING FOR A CHILD WHO HAS LEFT THE FAITH

At various points you will be tempted to give up on prayer altogether — the prayers have not worked, the child is further from the faith than she was five years ago, so why keep going — and the temptation is understandable and should be resisted. Keep praying, and change what you pray for. You have probably been praying, for years, some version of Lord, bring her back to faith, and that prayer is not wrong, but it is a prayer about a single distant outcome, and it wears you down when the outcome does not arrive on your schedule. Pray instead the prayers you can watch being answered in real time: pray for her protection today, pray for a kind person in her life today, pray that she feels loved today by you and by whoever else is in her orbit, pray that God will be present to her in whatever way she can receive him today. These are answered, most days, in small ways you will not always see but can trust — they keep the line open, they form you into a person practicing trust in what you cannot see rather than demanding evidence you cannot produce, and over the years they soften your own heart in ways the

DO NOT CARRY IT ALONE: FINDING SUPPORT AND PROTECTING YOUR MARRIAGE

You will often feel ashamed in church, and the church has often been the source of the shame even when it never intended to be: you sit through sermons on raising children in the fear of the Lord and feel like a fraud, you hear testimonies from other families whose children love Jesus and feel judged by implication, and you begin to dread the pew. That is understandable, and if it continues it will isolate you at exactly the moment you most need support. So find a community — inside your church or outside it — where you can be honest about what you are carrying, whether that is one other couple, or a small group of parents in the same situation, or a counselor who understands the particular grief, or, if your own church cannot hold it, a different church. The enemy of your soul during this stretch is isolation. Resist it at every cost.

*Your job is to love her. God's job is to
save her. The whole of your peace
depends on not mixing up the jobs.*

If you are married, the deconstruction of a child will

WHEN THE CHILD HAS REJECTED YOU: ESTRANGEMENT, APOLOGY, AND THE LONG SILENCE

Consider, specifically, the parent whose child has rejected not only the theology but the parent — the hardest case of all, in which the child has decided you were part of the problem, has in some instances gone no-contact or low-contact, and is telling other people a story about your faith-shaped parenting that you, from inside it, do not recognize. This is grief compounded by powerlessness, and there is no formula for it; there are only a few things worth saying. Examine the story she is telling as though it came from a stranger, because some of it may be more accurate than you can currently admit, and the reflex to defend yourself, however understandable, is

Where the story is not accurate, stay silent for now, because defending yourself to someone not ready to hear the defense only hardens the position. Time, kindness, consistent presence from a distance, and the Spirit do work that argument cannot. Trust that work.

**THE POSTURE, NOT THE TACTICS:
YOUR JOB IS TO LOVE, GOD'S JOB IS TO
SAVE**

There is a version of this chapter built around tactics — what to say and what not to say, how to handle Christmas, how to answer the social media post that horrifies you — but the tactics follow from the posture, and the posture is the thing that is hard. The parent with the right posture will figure out the tactics; the parent without it will not, no matter how many tactics she reads.

The posture is this: your child is a person, her relationship with God is not yours to guarantee, your love for her is unconditional and uncoerced, your hope is in a God who is patient beyond your patience, your prayer is that he will do what you cannot, your presence in her life is a gift given without expectation, and your own faith does not depend on hers, your identity as a Christian not contingent on her outcomes. Hold that posture, and build

There is a woman, seventy-one years old, who lost her son to the deconstruction wave twenty years ago, and who is now watching him move through his mid-forties. She has prayed for him every day of those twenty years and been careful never to badger him; she has welcomed him home, with his wife and their children, for every holiday, and spoken of the faith only when he asked; and in the last several years she has watched him begin to ask about certain things, tentatively, around the edges. She does not know whether he will ever return, and she has made her peace with not knowing. I have concluded, she said, that my job is to love him, and God's job is to save him, and I am not going to mix up the jobs anymore. That is the voice of a saint, formed over twenty years of grief held inside prayer — and it is the voice you can grow into, if you will let the grief be slowly worked by the Spirit into something that does not destroy you but instead forms you into the kind of Christian your child, if she ever comes home, will be glad to see.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Pastors in the Aftermath

*Pastoring After Deconstruction — Carrying the
Grief, Preaching Honestly, Holding Your Own
Doubts, and Leading a Church Through the Loss*

Every conversation about deconstruction is, at some point, a conversation about the pastor — and not the celebrity whose fall set the crisis in motion, but the ordinary one, the man who did not cover up the abuse, did not run an empire, did not fly private, did not build a brand, and who preaches three times a week, visits the hospital on Tuesdays, counsels the divorcing couple on Wednesdays, meets the deacons on Thursdays, and writes Sunday's sermon on Friday night because the week got away from him again. He is not the problem the deconstructors left. He is standing in the middle of the aftermath, trying to figure out what to do next. This chapter is for him.

What he is carrying, often without naming it, is a compound grief. There is the grief of loss — he has watched members leave over the last decade, and some of

These griefs compound over years, and he does not talk about them, because he was trained not to — and the training was mostly implicit. Nobody ever told him he could not name his own confusion; the culture of pastoral leadership simply modeled a confidence that left no room for it, and so he preaches faith, preaches trust, preaches the hope of the church, all while carrying, privately, the weight of what does not seem to be working. The weight shows up in his body, in his sleep, in his marriage — in ways his wife can see and he cannot.

So hear this clearly. The problem is real, the confusion is legitimate, and the grief is not a sign of failure but a sign that you are paying attention; the pastor who carries no version of this grief right now is either so insulated he has not noticed the situation or so hardened he has stopped feeling it, and neither condition is better than yours. You are awake. You are honest. Start there.

The first practical matter is your own theological formation, and many pastors, if they are honest, stopped reading somewhere around the time ministry demands swallowed the calendar. They read in seminary, they kept up with their favorite preachers and podcast guests, but they stopped reading the difficult books — because the difficult books require time they do not have and a mental energy that feels like a luxury — and the result, a decade on, is a pastor whose theological resources have not grown past what he carried at twenty-six, now fielding questions from a generation that has read widely and expects him to have read widely too. When he has not, the conversation fails, and the young adult walks away convinced the church has no resources to handle her questions. The church may well have them. The pastor simply does not have them at hand.

This is fixable. Read, and read past the preachers in your own tribe; read the people your deconstructing members are reading; read Charles Taylor's *A Secular Age* even if it takes a year, read David Bentley Hart even where you disagree, read Marilynne Robinson, read N. T. Wright's longer works rather than the popular summaries, read the early fathers even in translation. One difficult book a quarter, and guard the time the way you would guard a hospital visit — because that is what it is. Your mind is the instrument through which you serve the congregation; stop feeding it and the instrument goes dull, and dull sermons are, at this moment in the church's life, a luxury nobody can afford.

The second matter is how you preach, because the deconstructors in your pew, the pre-deconstructors, and the parents of deconstructors are all listening for the same thing — they are listening for honesty, for a sign that you know the world they are living in, that you have weighed the best version of their objections and not the straw man. A sermon that takes the real questions of the real people in the room and gives them their full weight before responding earns trust; a sermon that waves at those questions on the way to the pre-scheduled application point spends it. And you do not have enough trust left to keep spending it.

Be specific about what that preaching looks like. It means, sometimes, giving the first third of the sermon to the objection rather than the answer; it means describing the deconstructor's experience in terms she would recognize, not terms that caricature it; it means saying, from the pulpit, that you understand why someone would leave over this — a sentence that, spoken honestly, does more for your credibility than a year of relatable introductions. The congregation that hears you take the objection seriously will trust you when you give the response. The congregation that hears you dismiss it will conclude you do not understand their world, and the conclusion will be correct.

The hearing is the first ministry.

THE COFFEE, NOT THE EXAM: HOW TO HAVE THE PASTORAL CONVERSATION

The third matter is the pastoral conversation, and most pastors, on learning that a congregant is deconstructing, make the same predictable mistakes: they schedule a meeting too quickly, they arrive with an agenda — usually to identify the doctrinal problem and supply the corrective — and the conversation becomes an informal exam. The deconstructor, who came out of residual loyalty, senses she is being processed rather than heard, answers politely, and does not come back for the second meeting.

Try a different approach. When you learn that a congregant is deconstructing, do nothing pastoral for a while; pray, and let the information settle. Then, the next time you see her, ask her to get coffee, set no agenda, and do not call it counseling — and over that coffee, ask one question and listen. The question is this: what has been happening for you in the last year or two. That is the whole question, and everything she says in response is material you need, so listen without rebutting, listen without planning your reply, listen past the first answer and the second answer into the third, which is usually the real one. When the real answer comes, stay with it; do not reach for the scriptural corrective, because the corrective may come later, in another conversation, once she has had the experience of being heard by a representative of the

GRIEF, REFORM, AND YOUR OWN FAITH: COUNSEL FOR THE PASTOR WHO DOUBTS

The fourth matter is grief counseling — for you. You need someone to talk to about this, and your spouse is not the right person, not because she does not care but because she carries her own version of the grief, and the last thing she needs is to be your therapist. What you need is a counselor, a spiritual director, or a peer group of pastors in the same situation; if your denomination provides pastoral counseling, use it, and if it does not, find it, paying for it out of the continuing education budget if your church has one, asking a denominational leader for help if you cannot afford it. Do not carry this alone, because alone is how pastors break.

The fifth matter is what you tell your congregation about the people who have left. The temptation is to say nothing, because saying something feels like airing dirty laundry — but the result is a silence the remaining congregation fills with its own stories, which are usually worse than the truth. Better to name the reality, generally, without naming names; something like this, from the pulpit, at the right time. Some of you have noticed that people you love are no longer here. You are right. People have left. Some left because we failed them, and we need to own that; some left because they are working through questions that take time; some left for reasons we do not know. What I want to say is that we pray for them, we hold the door open for them, and we do not speak of them as

That language, from the pulpit, does two things at once: it tells the remaining congregation how to treat the people who have left, and it tells them the pastor sees the situation clearly. Both messages are needed, and both, in most congregations, go unspoken.

The sixth matter is institutional reform. Suppose you have read the case for the church we could become and thought, yes, but my deacons would never go for it, or my denomination would not allow it — some of those barriers are real and some are imagined, and the work is to determine which is which. The pastor who says his deacons would never allow background checks on youth volunteers has not, in most cases, actually asked; he has assumed the answer. So ask. Present the case, bring the data, and let the deacons decide rather than deciding for them; if they say no, make the case again in six months, and if they say no again, decide what you are willing to risk. Every reform in the history of the church has cost someone something. Yours will cost you too. Decide what the cost is worth.

The seventh matter is your own faith, and someone has to address it. You are a pastor in the aftermath of a crisis in which the institution you serve has been publicly discredited, which is not a comfortable place to stand and which, for some pastors, is a quietly corrosive one — because the doubts you preach about on Sunday

So hear this too. Your questions are legitimate, and your faith is not invalidated by them; the counsel this book has offered the deconstructing layperson applies, with adjustments, to you — read widely, practice the ancient disciplines, find a spiritual director, pray the psalms of lament. You are permitted, as a pastor, to hold a complicated faith, permitted to hold the questions inside the vocation rather than stepping outside it to hold them. Moses held questions. Jeremiah held questions. The apostles held questions repeatedly, inside the Gospels, often in the form of bewildered looks and wrong answers — and you are in their company, so stay in it. The faith that emerges from this season of questioning, if you stay with it, is the faith your congregation needs you to have: it will be tested, it will be textured, and it will be able to stand in the pulpit and say to the doubter, I know the terrain you are describing, because I have walked in it; come, let us walk it together. That is the shepherd's voice, and it is the voice this generation is waiting to hear. It has not heard it often enough.

A MINISTRY OF HOLDING: CARRYING GRIEF AND FAITH AT ONCE

One final note. Pastoral ministry has always been, in part, a ministry of holding — you hold the wedding and the funeral, you hold the sick and the confused, you hold the teenager who tried to kill herself and the widow who wants

What this season of the church's life asks of you is to hold one more thing: the grief and the faith at once. The holding will not be resolved in your lifetime, and the crisis will outlast your ministry; what you can do, inside your ministry, is hold it well — hold it honestly, hold it without pretending it is not heavy, hold it inside a faith that has carried heavier things, across worse centuries, and survived.



*I have said these things to you, that in me you may
have peace. In the world you will have tribulation.
But take heart; I have overcome the world.*

— JOHN 16:33

That faith is yours. It has not abandoned you. Hold on.

CONCLUSION

What We Owe Each Other

*What Those Who Stayed and Those Who Left Owe
Each Other — Loving Across the Line Between
Faith and Deconstruction*

A line has been drawn through American families, churches, and friendships, and on one side stand the people who have continued in the faith as they received it, while on the other stand the people who have left, or who are leaving, or who are deep in the long work of revising what they believe. The line is real, and there is no use pretending otherwise. What has happened across it is that the two sides have, in many cases, stopped talking altogether — and when they do talk, they talk past each other, each writing only to its own tribe. The question this book has refused to abandon is the one neither tribe wants answered honestly: what do they owe each other across that line.

TO THE CHRISTIANS WHO STAYED:

You owe the people who have left more than you have been giving them — patience, honesty, and the acknowledgment that the institution they walked out of has, in fact, often failed in exactly the ways they say it failed. You owe them, sometimes, an apology, and not the corporate kind, which is easy and costs nothing, but the personal kind, from you to them, for the ways your own version of the faith may have been part of what pushed them out the door. Perhaps you did none of it yourself; perhaps you were faithful the whole time. It does not matter. You are a member of the body that failed them, and when members of the body have done wrong, the body confesses. That is how bodies work.

You owe them your presence — not your arguments, not your pamphlets, not your scheduled counseling appointments, but your presence: the willingness to sit at dinner without steering the conversation toward their soul, to text them on their birthday without embedding a verse, to hold them in your mind and your prayers without filing them under unfinished business. Ask most who have left what they want from the Christians in their lives, and the first answer is almost always the same — I want them to stop trying to fix me. They are not projects. They are people. Treat them as people, and you are most of the way to being the Christian they needed.

You owe them, finally, the admission that you do not know how their story ends — whether they will come back, whether they will land in some tradition not your own, whether they will die outside the institutional church and inside a relationship with Christ you have no instrument to measure. You do not have the standing to pronounce on

TO THE CHRISTIANS WHO HAVE LEFT: WHAT YOU OWE THE ONES YOU LEFT

You owe the people you have left more than some of you have been giving them. You owe them the honesty of admitting that some of your reasons for leaving were reasons and some were rationalizations, and you owe them the maturity of not flattening the whole institution into the worst version of it you ever met. You owe them, in many cases, a distinction between the person who wounded you and the tradition that shaped that person — because the tradition, read honestly, would have corrected the very person you are rejecting. And you owe them patience as they try to figure out how to speak to you, because many of them are frightened, many believe they failed you, and many cannot raise the subject without making it worse. Give them a little grace. They are people too.

You owe yourself the honesty of finding out what the tradition actually is before you shut the door, because if you ask those who have left what they have read of the Christian tradition, many admit they have read almost nothing beyond their own former subculture: the old youth pastor and not Augustine, the popular podcast and not Athanasius, the algorithm and not the desert fathers. That is their right. But a final judgment on the faith rendered without acquaintance with the faith — in its full historical and theological shape — is a judgment rendered too soon.

You owe the next generation more than bitterness. The bitterness is understandable — it can be felt in the rooms where these stories are told, and much of it is warranted — but what it cannot do is form a child. A parent whose only religious content with her children is the story of how terrible her childhood religion was has not handed them a faith; she has handed them her bitterness, and they will inherit it stripped of the context that produced it, and it will do its work on them in ways she never intended. If you are a parent, weigh what you are passing on, because the honest account of what you survived is a gift and the bitterness is not, and the willingness to seek something better, even unfound, is a gift and the shrug is not. Your children are watching, and they are not sure what to make of you. Give them enough to work with.

The line is real. The wall is optional.

Do not let the line become a wall.

**THE THREAT BOTH SIDES SHARE:
WHEN THE LINE BECOMES A WALL**

Refusing the wall asks something specific of those who stayed: it asks them to stop policing the edges, to resist the reflex to write off the old friend who no longer posts verses, to choose again that their love for this person is unconditional and not contingent on his theological trajectory — and that choice, made and remade, is what kept many in the door through their most dangerous years, and it can keep others in the door now. It asks something of those who left as well: to resist the mirror-image policing of their own tribe, to refuse the thrill of the anti-evangelical dunk, to sit sometimes with a family member still inside the faith and let her be inside it, without converting her, condescending to her, or subjecting her to a lecture. The relationship matters more than the comfort of the positions inside it. Choose the relationship.

Consider also the children. Many who have left are now parents, raising children without the church, or with a complicated relationship to it, or inside a tradition not

WHAT COMES AFTER: THE FUTURE OF THE AMERICAN CHURCH

The God of the Bible is not finished with the church in America. The judgment that has been falling is real, and painful, and deserved — but judgment in the biblical imagination is not the end of the story; it is the door to repentance, and repentance is the door to renewal, and renewal is what the Spirit is in the business of producing in churches with the humility to receive it. No one knows what the American church will look like in twenty years, or how much of the present institutional architecture will survive, but the people of God do not vanish:



— MATTHEW 16:18

Whatever institutional form the church takes in the next generation, Christ will be at its center, the Scriptures in its hands, the sacraments at its table, the Spirit in its breath, the saints in its fellowship, and the broken in its pews. It will not be the church we had; it will be the one God is building. It is worth staying to help build, it is worth coming back to if you have left, and it is worth praying for if you are not sure where you stand.

The conversation is not over, and the deconstruction wave is not the last word; what comes after, attended to honestly, can be the chastened, durable Christianity that our children and their children will need. Let us tell the truth. Let us love each other across the line that has been drawn. And let us, when the Spirit moves, answer with the only answer the Spirit accepts. Here I am.

